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TTP SUSPECTED

14 killed in
suicide attack
on peace rally
in Pakistan



WORLD » PAGE 12

AGENCY AND VULNERABILITY

Analysing the
SC's judgment
on sex work

The need for guidelines,
compliance, and training

OPINION » PAGE 7



SCRIPTING HISTORY

Tanvi is the youngest
Taipei Open champ

SPORT » PAGE 14

Cauvery water from Kabini to reach Tamil Nadu today

The Hindu Bureau
SALEM

Water released from the Kabini Dam in Karnataka is expected to reach the Tamil Nadu boundary on Monday and flow into the Mettur Dam by Monday night or Tuesday, according to Water Resources Department (WRD) officials.

The Karnataka government, following heavy rainfall over the past few days, began releasing Cauvery water from the Kabini Dam on Saturday.

Officials had initially expected the water to reach Tamil Nadu by Sunday evening.

However, the flow has been delayed by the dry Cauvery riverbed, which has absorbed a significant amount of the released water, affecting its downstream movement.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 8

Cauvery situation slightly better, says Karnataka CM

Releasing limited quantity of water to T.N. for drinking purposes, says Shivakumar after all-party meet; he reiterates need for Mekedatu project, appeals to protesters to withdraw Aug. 13 bandh

Sharath S. Srivatsa
Laigh A. Khan
BENGALURU/MYSURU

Stating that the water situation in the Cauvery was “slightly better” in view of the rain, Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar on Sunday reiterated his appeal to the Kannada organisations to withdraw their State-wide bandh plan for August 13.

However, Kannada Chaluvali leader Vatal Nagaraj, who is leading the protest, said the bandh would be held as planned.

At an all-party meeting, the Chief Minister said Karnataka was carefully assessing the Cauvery situation, including a petition filed in the Supreme Court by the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam, the Opposition party in Tamil Nadu.



Karnataka CM D.K. Shivakumar with former CMs B.S. Yeddiurappa and Siddaramaiah at an all-party meet. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

A limited quantity of water was being released from the reservoirs following rain, he said.

The meeting had been convened to address the concerns over the Cauvery Water Management Authority (CWMA)’s directive to the State to abide by the Cauvery Water Regulation Committee’s order to re-

lease 3,500 cusecs daily to Tamil Nadu for 15 days. The order set off protests in parts of Karnataka.

The data shared by the Water Resources Department show that Karnataka was releasing water at the rate of 25,000 cusecs from the Kabini reservoir and 1,819 cusecs from the Krishnaraja Sagar on Sunday to

Tamil Nadu. “We are releasing a limited quantity of water through canals only to fill lakes and tanks meant for drinking water purposes, and not for irrigation,” he said.

Reiterating that the proposed Mekedatu project on the Cauvery was the long-term solution to the problems faced by both States, he said: “Karnataka will respect the law and orders of the Supreme Court while protecting the State’s interest”. He said Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay had agreed to postpone his visit to Bengaluru to discuss the issue on the request of the Karnataka government.

CONTINUED ON
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EDITORIAL
» PAGE 6

NEARBY



T.N. government to expand scope of credit scheme

CHENNAI
The government has decided to implement the Singapermal Credit Scheme by broadening the scope of lending through cooperatives to include youth and marginalised sections as beneficiaries. » PAGE 2

5 killed as car rams parked water tanker

COIMBATORE
Five persons, including four family members, died after their car ramed a stationary water tanker on the Pollachi-Udumalpet stretch of NH 83 at Thippampatti on Sunday. » PAGE 2

EDUCATIONPLUS » PAGE 5

PM launches drive to curb drug abuse among youth

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Stressing the need for sustained action and community participation to combat drug abuse, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday laid out a national vision for building a drugs-free youth population as the foundation of “Viksit Bharat” (developed India).

Launching the *Nasha Mukti Yuva* for Viksit Bharat *Sankalp Abhiyan* (Drug-Free Youth for Developed India Pledge Campaign), Mr. Modi said that today’s youth would eventually enjoy the fruits of a developed India.

FULL REPORT ON
» PAGE 8

Fuming ferry



Tragic crossing: Smoke rising from a passenger ferry which caught fire off Indonesia’s Madura island in East Java on Sunday. At least five persons were killed while efforts were on to find more than 40 missing people after many jumped overboard. REUTERS (REPORT: PAGE 12)

Deal close, U.S., Israel to hold off on Iran strike, says Trump

Associated Press
WASHINGTON

U.S. President Donald Trump has said that he will order American forces to hold off on new strikes against Iran, claiming West Asia allies have reached the parameters of a deal to end the five-month war.

The emerging deal “would include the immediate, complete, and total” opening of the Strait of Hormuz and “an end to Iran’s nuclear threat”, Mr. Trump wrote in a social media post on Saturday evening. He said Israel is joining his commitment to end the war. Israel did not publicly comment on the announcement.

A regional official said the proposal calls for the U.S. and Iran to return to



Donald Trump

negotiations. The U.S., in exchange, will end its naval blockade on Iran, he said. No deal has been reached yet, but mediation efforts are under way, said the official, who is involved in mediation efforts and spoke on condition of anonymity.

The U.S. was prepared to go against Iran “at levels of military terror, strength, and power” not seen since the Second World War, Mr.

Trump said in his post, claiming that Iran asked the U.S. to hold off on any attack.

However, Iran’s Mehr news agency denied Mr. Trump’s claim that Tehran asked Washington to refrain from conducting new strikes, saying it was “nothing but a new lie”.

Iran’s Defence Ministry said that the country was “neither surprised nor passive” following the announcement, and added that Iran continued to remain alert in the face of concrete threats from the U.S.

Mr. Trump has announced halts to strikes in Iran on several occasions since the U.S. and Israel attacked Iran on February 28, only for things to unravel and fighting to resume.

Petrol, diesel consumption surges in July; LPG use down despite rollback of curbs

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

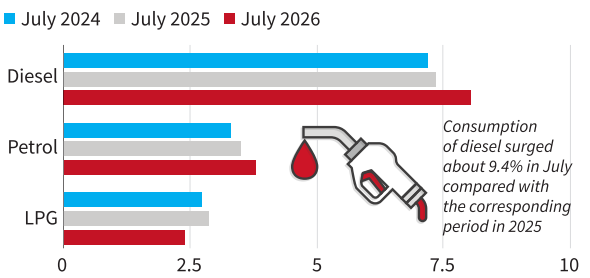
Consumption of diesel and petrol surged about 9.4% and 8.7% year-on-year respectively in July, primarily driven by a below-average monsoon that increased the demand for fuel among farmers to run irrigation machinery and tractors.

According to government data, diesel consumption in July touched about 8.05 million metric tonnes (MMT), higher than 7.356 MMT last July. Petrol consumption stood at 3.795 MMT as against 3.493 MMT in the comparable period last year.

Sale of diesel – which powers transport, agricul-

Surging volumes

The chart shows the consumption of diesel, petrol, and LPG for the month of July. Figures in MMT (million metric tonnes)



Note: Numbers are provisional. Propane and butane is included in LPG stream
Source: Petroleum Planning & Analysis Cell

tural equipment, and irrigation – is a key indicator of economic activity. Usually, fuel sales dip with the onset of monsoon amid reduced deployment

of agricultural pumps and vehicular movement. But this year, the rain arrived late, and was uneven, due to which farmers deployed diesel-powered pumps to

irrigate fields for the kharif season.

LPG use falls

Consumption of Liquefied Petroleum Gas (LPG) declined 17.4% during the reported period to 2.373 MMT. The fall came despite the government restoring the supply of industrial and commercial LPG to pre-West Asia crisis levels and withdrawing sector-specific allocation caps on June 25.

This also coincided with the increased adoption of piped natural gas by domestic and industrial consumers.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 8

With five gold medallists, Haryana town fuels India’s best-ever CWG boxing haul

Ashok Kumar
GURUGRAM

For decades, the dusty town of Bhiwani, about 100 km from Delhi, has punched far above its weight in boxing rings around the world. On Saturday, its boxers scripted history for India at the Glasgow Commonwealth Games, powering the country to a haul of 10 medals, its best-ever performance in the sport at the Games. Of the seven gold medallists, five come from Bhiwani, which is often hailed as the “Mini Cuba” of India, a tribute to the Caribbean island nation that has produced a slew of famed boxers.



Priya Ghanghas, left, who won a gold medal, practises at a training centre in Bhiwani in April. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

India’s first boxer to win an Olympic medal, Vijender Singh, shot the town into the global spotlight in 2008, winning a bronze at Beijing, and sparking a victorious streak for dozens of

other boxers from Bhiwani.

On Saturday, four Bhiwani women climbed the podium in Glasgow – Sakshi Chaudhary (51 kg), Preeti Pawar (54 kg), Jais-

mine Lamboria (57kg), and Priya Ghanghas (60 kg) – along with one man, Sachin Siwach (60 kg).

Jagdish Singh, who heads the Bhiwani Boxing Club that has played a major role in scripting the town’s dominance in the sport, credited the record haul to changes in the selection process for the 2026 Games.

The current transparent and trial-based selection process would also help India in the upcoming Asian Games and 2028 Olympics, he told *The Hindu*.

CONTINUED ON
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SATISFYING GLASGOW SHOW
» PAGE 13



A photograph of the Kumbharwade Temple in Hampi. The temple features a prominent stone structure with a dome and a person standing nearby. The architecture is a mix of Vijayanagara and Hoysaleswara styles.

INBRIEF



R. RAGU

Run held to create awareness of liver health, preventive care

A liver health awareness run was organised by the Liver Foundation at C. Kandaswami Naidu College in Anna Nagar on Sunday to promote healthy lifestyles and preventive healthcare. Anna Nagar MLA V.K. Ramkumar flagged off the event, which included a 3-km awareness walk and a 5-km run. The organisers said the initiative sought to encourage regular physical activity and timely screening for liver diseases. About 1,500 people participated in the event, a release said.

Walkathon organised to stress importance of breastfeeding

A breastfeeding awareness walkathon was held at Besant Nagar Beach on Sunday, ahead of World Breastfeeding Week, bringing together healthcare professionals, students, nurses and volunteers to promote its importance. Organised by the Neonatology Association of Tamil Nadu, in association with the Rotary Club of Chennai Kilpauk, the event highlighted exclusive breastfeeding for the first six months, continued breastfeeding with appropriate complementary feeding, and the role of human milk banks in improving outcomes for sick and preterm newborns.

Police search for 2 persons involved in youth's death

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Anna Nagar police have launched a search for two persons in connection with the death of a 23-year-old, who fell from the fourth floor of a building in Anna Nagar on Saturday.

The city police said S. Akash, a native of Ramana-nathapuram district, worked for a private travel agency in Anna Nagar. It is alleged that funds totalling ₹40 lakh had been misappropriated from the company. Its owner, along with two others – Senthil Kumar and Dilli – had called Akash to enquire about the missing funds. On Saturday, Akash's sister received information that he fell from the company building, and was admitted to a private hospital. But he died later that night.

The police registered a case and arrested one person, who was later released on bail. With the victim's relatives alleging foul play, the police have launched a search for two persons accused of brutally attacking Akash, causing him to fall from the balcony while trying to escape.

Metro Rail yet to complete construction of entry, exit at Vadapalani Phase II station

Officials say the work was delayed due to shortage of workers, as many of them went to vote in Assembly polls; the work has seen good progress in last two months and will be completed soon

TRACK TALES

Sunitha Sekar
CHENNAI

Chennai Metro Rail may have received the final approval to operate the Poonamallee-Vadapalani stretch of the Phase II project for passenger operations, but the entry/exit point of Vadapalani station is yet to be completed.

Since February, commuters have been waiting for the launch of the Poonamallee-Vadapalani stretch. Construction works at the stations between Poonamallee and Porur have been finished in entirety except Vadapalani station, where the entry/exit construction has not been completed, sources said.

When the opening of this stretch was scheduled in February, Chennai Metro Rail said those using the Vadapalani Phase II sta-



Poor planning: Commuters boarding or alighting at Vadapalani might need to endure a long walk and go through the entry/exit of the Phase I station once the Phase II stretch is opened. M. SRINATH

tion would be able to use the skywalk and enter or exit via the Vadapalani Phase I station.

Chennai Metro Rail Limited (CMRL) officials said that stations between Porur and Vadapalani would be ready by June, including the entry/exit point for the Vadapalani Phase II station.

With the Centre's permission for the opening of the stretch is expected this

month, commuters boarding or alighting at Vadapalani might need to endure a longer walk and go through the entry/exit of the Phase I station, sources said. It is to be noted that the entry/exit of the Vadapalani Phase I station is located at Jawaharlal Nehru Salai and that of the Vadapalani Phase II station on Arcot Road.

According to officials of CMRL, they faced a short-

tage of workers for a couple of months when the Assembly elections were held.

“But, there has been good progress in the last two months as the workers returned, and we will finish the work soon,” an official said.

Sources said that the contractor in-charge of constructing the Vadapalani's Phase II entry/exit had failed despite having plenty of time to finish the work. “In the last four months, the contractor could have easily built this entry/exit point since Vadapalani is a key station for the Poonamallee-Vadapalani stretch. This is an unreasonable delay,” a source said.

Cherian Thomas, a resident of Vadapalani, said people like him use the metro for its convenience, but the charm to travel would be lost when they have to walk a longer distance to board and alight.

NGT impleads HPCL in groundwater pollution case

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Southern Bench of the National Green Tribunal (NGT) has impleaded Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Limited (HPCL) and a Bharat Petroleum Corporation Limited (BPCL) fuel outlet dealer as additional respondents in the suo motu case concerning the alleged contamination of groundwater with petrol in Kovilambakkam.

The NGT initiated the case based on a news report that highlighted residents' concerns over the groundwater contamination. A Bench comprising judicial member Justice Pushpa Sathyanarayana and expert member Prashant Gargava, in an order passed on July 28, allowed an application to implead HPCL as the seventh respondent. It also suo motu impleaded Immanuel Agencies, the BPCL dealer, as the eighth respondent.

The Tamil Nadu Pollution Control Board, HPCL, and the fuel outlet dealer have been directed to file their respective reports or replies before the next hearing on August 24.

Two arrested for attack on police officials

CHENNAI: Two persons were arrested for allegedly attacking police officials when the latter tried to stop a clash between two groups of transgender individuals in Ennore on Sunday.

Police said a patrol team rushed to the Ennore Tsunami Quarters to stop the clash. When the police tried to stop the altercation, some members of the clashing groups attacked the police officials. The arrested were identified as Brindha, 29, and Anjali, 31.

31 national highways to get smart lighting system

Deepa H. Ramakrishnan
CHENNAI

The National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) has called for tenders to install smart lighting systems on 31 highways across northern and parts of central Tamil Nadu.

The existing lighting system will become fully automated. “The lights will turn on at sunset and remain on till daybreak. The timings will change according to the season. We will be able to identify when a bulb or switch stops working and replace it immediately,” an official said.



Dispelling darkness: The NHAI is taking steps to improve lighting on highways in north and central Tamil Nadu. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

A single tender has been floated for all the stretches. “The tender process has

been structured in such a way that the work is expected to begin in October. The selected contractor

will have one year to complete the installation and testing,” another official said.

This follows the successful implementation of a pilot project from Tambaram to Tindivanam, where visibility improved after an Internet of Things-based lighting system was installed along the 95-km stretch of the Chennai-Tiruchi National Highway.

“Everyone, from maintenance personnel and NHAI officials to supervisors, can now monitor the lights online. Lighting is provided at junctions and

settlements along the National Highways,” the official added.

Narayanan Ram, a resident of Sholinganallur, said the smart lights were a welcome addition and provided exactly what was needed. “Lighting installations that are more than 20 years old must also be replaced. Lights should also be installed at cattle crossings and places where people cross the highway late at night. Perhaps, it is time to install such lighting systems in cities as well, where street lighting is often inadequate,” he said.

History-sheeter found dead with injuries in New Washermenpet

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A 24-year-old fisherman and history-sheeter from New Washermenpet, was found dead in suspicious circumstances on Sunday. The Fishing Harbour Police have filed a case and are investigating.

A senior official of the city police said E. Naresh Kumar was a resident of Poondi Thangammal

Street in New Washermenpet. He had more than 12 criminal cases pending against him including murder and attempt to murder.

Naresh Kumar was recently released on bail in a murder case in July. In the early hours of Sunday, the police found him dead at the entrance of 'B' Block of the Slum Clearance Board Housing on Poondi Thangammal Street with injuries on his face.

Correction

In the report “DMK to boycott verification of EVMs in Kolathur alleging lapses; plans to go to court”, on Page 4 of Chennai city edition dated August 2, 2026, it was wrongly mentioned that Bharat Heavy Electricals Limited is supervising the EVMs verification. It should have been Bharat Electronics Limited.

Timings CHENNAI

MONDAY, AUG. 03		
RISE	05:55	SET 18:35
RISE	21:48	SET 09:36
TUESDAY, AUG. 04		
RISE	05:55	SET 18:35
RISE	22:28	SET 10:27
WEDNESDAY, AUG. 05		
RISE	05:56	SET 18:35
RISE	23:13	SET 11:21

Chennai Weather	max	min
Tiruvallur	39	28
Chennai Airport	38	28
Chennai City	38	28

Chennai Airport Today
38°C The weather will be mostly dry. Day will be slightly hot with an uneasy afternoon. Night will also be uneasy.

Chennai Airport Tomorrow
37°C Morning will be comfortable. Day will be very warm and uneasy. Night will also be uneasy. Spell of rain and thundershowers may occur.

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THE HINDU

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CINEMA ♦ ARTS ♦ EVENTS

MUSIC DANCE DRAMA

The Music Academy Madras
36th SPIRIT OF YOUTH FESTIVAL OF MUSIC AND DANCE Today: At the Kasturi Srinivasan Hall, 6 p.m. to 7.15 p.m. Shreyas Bharadwaj (Flute), Sanjay Rajesh (Violin), Tejaswi Shashidhar (Mridangam) – 7.30 p.m. to 9 p.m. – Bharatanatyam by Jyothsna Akilan (Disciple of Anitha Guha). Members of the Academy are specially invited. The festival sponsored by SUNDAM FASTENERS LIMITED and dedicated to the memory of Smt. Ambujam Krishna.

Narada Gana Sabha
Tel: 24993201
Today Mini Hall (Swami Haridhosh Giri Hall) – 6.30 p.m. – Talent Promotion Concerts – Hari Dharmarajan Endowment – C. Ramakrishna, Chetana Shekar, Prahalad V. Tomorrow – 6.30 p.m. – Surya Sriram. All are welcome.

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SRIMAD BHAGHAVADA SAPTHAHAM By Dr. Smt. SUDHA SESHAYYAN (SPONSORED PROGRAMME) Late Hemalatha Family Members From 3/8/2026 To 9/8/2026 (Monday to Sunday) at Sringeri Pravachana Mandiram 23, Sringeri Mutt Road, R A Puram, Ch-28 (opposite Mandaveli Railway Station). All are welcome.

Sri Thiagaraja Sangeetha Vidwath Samajam, Mylapore
Today, Panchami Abhishegam Pooja. 6.30 p.m. Bharathi Ramaswami - Vocal, Navaneethakrishnan - Violin, Punanoor Viswanathan - Mridangam. All are welcome. www.srithiagarajasamajam.org

MISCELLANEOUS

Sri Vishnu Mohan Foundation, Chennai in association with **Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan,** Chennai Kendra celebrates “**Sri Krishna Utsavam**” from 31.7.2026 to 5.8.2026.

Today: 3rd August: 5.45 pm: Vocal Concert by **Dr.Vaishnavi Ramadas**, 7.00 pm: Odissi by **Dr.Sujata Mohapatra**. Prasadam distribution at 8.30 pm. Tomorrow: 4th August: 5.45 pm: Mohiniyattam by **Dr.Gopika Varma**, 7.00 pm: Bharatanatyam by **Smt.Padmini Krishnamurthy & Students**, Sri Saraswathy Gana Nilayam Trust. Valet Parking available. **All are Welcome.**

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PERSONAL

CHANGE OF NAME

I, HITHERTO known as Latha B d/o Bagdaram r/o 142 A Main Road Kaladipet Tiruvottiyur, Mathavaram, Tiruvallur, Tamil Nadu- 600019, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as Ira Gehlot.

MY SON, S. Mithesh, born on 18th August 2012 (District of Birth: Kancheepuram), residing at No. 43, Abirami Street, Andharapatti Road, Tiruchirappalli-621 211, shall henceforth be known as **MITHESH SENTHILNATHAN** Tiruchirappalli, 29th June 2026. S. SENTHILNATHAN (Father)

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E-TENDER NOTIFICATION
NO. C6/420/2026/T dt.01.08.2026
Notice for e-Tender Cme e-Auction for Allotment of Covered space Exim Godown No.4 4500 sq.m at Eastern side of Marshalling Yard Road in III Section inside the custom bound area for the purpose of Handling Break Bulk Cargo with installation of Mechanized Gantry Crane for a period of 5 years on annual licence basis in as is where is condition without renewal option, under two cover system from 01.08.2026 to 21.08.2026. For further details visit Ch.P.A. website www.chennaiport.gov.in and www.eprocure.gov.in

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Zubeda Hamid
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INBRIEF



A.P., Australia sign four MoUs on education, clean energy

Andhra Pradesh and Australia have signed four memoranda of understanding (MoUs) in the fields of clean energy, advanced manufacturing, inclusive education, student mental health, and skill development. The agreements were signed in the presence of Andhra Pradesh HRD Minister Nara Lokesh and Australia's Assistant Minister Julian Hill, a statement said. One of the MoUs propose to establish a Centre of Excellence for Solar Manufacturing at IIT-Tirupati.

Drunk man drives away bus in A.P., held after long chase

A man in an inebriated condition drove away a public transport bus from Kadiri in Sri Sathya Sai district to Madanapalle in Annamayya district, covering 80 km, on Friday night. This resulted in a police chase that ended several hours later with his arrest on Saturday. The accused, Siva Prasad, 45, arrived at the Kadiri RTC bus stand on Friday night, intending to travel to Madanapalle. As there was no bus available at night, he got into a parked APSRTC bus and drove away.

Container ship goes adrift while leaving Cochin Port

A container ship leaving the Cochin port in Kerala reportedly suffered an engine failure and went adrift on Saturday night, triggering a brief period of tension. Sources said that the vessel, *SSL Mumbai*, was brought to safety by two tugboats accompanying it. The vessel was proceeding to its designated anchorage area when it suffered the glitch about an hour after leaving the port. The ship has been moored at Ernakulam Wharf Q7.

Tata Trusts to create centres for education, healthcare: Chairman

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Noel Tata, Chairman of Tata Trusts, said on Sunday that the philanthropic arm of the Tata Group has decided to move beyond its traditional role of supporting non-governmental organisations and development programmes to create institutions capable of serving future generations. Participating in a fire-side chat at IIMBue 2026, an annual conclave hosted by old students of the Indian Institute of Management-Bangalore, Mr. Tata outlined the future direction of Tata Trusts, emphasising institution-building over project-based philanthropy and reaffirming a philosophy that has shaped the Tata Group for more than a century. He unveiled a new roadmap for one of India's largest philanthropic organisations, signalling a strategic shift toward building enduring institutions in healthcare and education, while calling for greater accountability in philanthropy. "The founders left their shares in the companies to the Trusts with one message: do good for India. They never said to become the biggest company. The companies exist to serve India and improve the quality of life," he said.

'Revives a legacy'

The new strategy revives a legacy that produced some of India's most respected public institutions, including the Indian Institute of Science, Tata Institute of Fundamental Research and Tata Memorial Hospital. According to Mr. Noel,



Noel Tata

as part of this renewed focus, the trust will establish 40 to 50 not-for-profit general hospitals. The proposed hospitals will operate on a cross-subsidy model, where premium-paying patients help finance treatment for economically weaker sections without compromising the quality of doctors, medicines, or infrastructure. Mr. Tata stated that education would be another major area of investment, describing the proposed undergraduate institution being developed in partnership with IIM Bangalore as an important beginning. He argued that India urgently needs many more world-class higher education institutions and expressed concern that thousands of talented Indian students continue to leave the country each year due to the limited availability of quality institutions. Beyond expanding healthcare and education, he said that philanthropy must become more accountable. Charitable organisations should move beyond broad claims of impact and instead demonstrate measurable outcomes, he said.

Rain death toll rises to 11 in Kerala; 7,600 in relief camps

IMD places all 14 districts of the State on yellow alert today, no heavy rainfall alert for Tuesday and Wednesday; sanitation work launched in places where floodwaters have receded, says Satheesan

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The death toll in rain-related incidents in Kerala rose to 11 by Sunday, even as more than 7,600 people were evacuated to relief camps across the State, the government said. Rain continued across most districts of Kerala on Sunday, though with reduced intensity, allowing authorities to step up relief operations. Four people have died so far in Malappuram district, two each in Thiruvananthapuram, Alappuzha and Idukki and one in Kozhikode, Revenue Minister A.P. Anilkumar said on Sunday. Populated regions remained heavily water-



Submerged home: A flooded house in Nedumpram village near Thiruvalla in Pathanamthitta district of Kerala. LEJU KAMAL

logged, disrupting normal life. Across the State, 7,674 people have been shifted to 273 camps, equipped with drinking water, food and medical facilities, Mr. Anilkumar said. Steps are being taken to prevent the outbreak of epidemics. Thirty houses have been destroyed in the rain havoc

so far while 293 have been reported damaged. All districts except Thiruvananthapuram and Kollam were on orange alert on Sunday. The India Meteorological Department has placed all 14 districts on yellow alert for isolated heavy rainfall on Monday. As a pre-

caution, holiday has been declared for educational institutions in the districts of Kasaragod, Kannur, Kozhikode, Malappuram, Palakkad, Wayanad, Thrissur, Idukki, Kottayam and Pathanamthitta. The IMD has not issued heavy rainfall alerts for Tuesday and Wednesday, but northern districts are likely to receive isolated heavy rainfall by Thursday. The Kerala State Disaster Management Authority directed the District Tourism Promotion Councils to regulate activities at waterfalls and high-range tourist spots. Chief Minister V.D. Sath-eesan said that sanitation works have been launched in regions where the floodwaters have receded.

Couple, son killed in Karnataka landslip

The Hindu Bureau
TIRTHAHALLI

Three people were killed in a landslip in Tirthahalli town in Shivamogga district of Karnataka early on Saturday morning. The deceased have been identified as Malikarjun, around 30, his wife Nagaveni, around 27, and their three-year-old son Santosh of Kakkargol in Koppal district of the State. They had come to Tirthahalli four days ago to work on plantations, leaving behind their

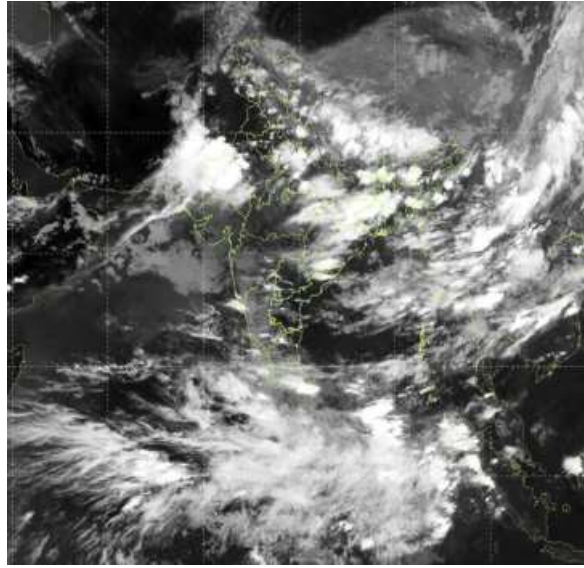
two daughters at their village. The family was living in a shed just beneath a hillock in the Gandhi Nagar locality of Tirthahalli town. Following heavy rain, landslips occurred around 3.30 a.m., trapping four residents under the debris. One rescued One of them was rescued by a Fire and Emergency Services team in the morning and has been admitted to hospital. Later, the bodies of the

couple and their child were retrieved from the debris with the help of earthmovers. Every year, hundreds of people from several districts of north Karnataka migrate to the Malnad region in search of work, finding jobs on plantations and construction sites and in quarries. The workers had been allotted vacant land at Gandhi Nagar, where they had put up sheds covered with zinc sheets, partitioned into compartments

for each family with more sheets of zinc. Workers shifted The taluk administration has shifted all of them to a temporary care centre at Dr. B.R. Ambedkar Bhavan in the town. Shivamogga Assistant Commissioner Satyanarayana, Tirthahalli tahsildar S. Ranjith, and senior police officers monitored the rescue operation. The process for granting compensation to the victims' family would begin shortly, the officials said.

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday



TEMPERATURE DATA: IMD, POLLUTION DATA: CPCB, MAP: INSAT/IMD (TAKEN AT 17.00 HRS)

Forecast for Monday: Heavy to very heavy rainfall very likely at isolated places over Arunachal Pradesh, Bihar, West Bengal and Sikkim. Thunderstorm accompanied with lightning and gusty winds (40-50kmph) very likely at isolated places over Andaman and Nicobar Islands, coastal Andhra Pradesh, Kerala, Mahe, Lakshadweep, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Puducherry and Karaikal.

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala		33.2	26.6	Kurnool		1.2	35.5
Ahmedabad		12.0	31.0	Lucknow		0.6	35.2
Aizawl		0.5	32.8	Madurai			37.5
Bangaluru		1.5	31.3	Mangaluru		3.4	28.1
Bhopal			23.3	Mumbai		2.6	31.0
Bhubaneswar			34.5	Mysuru			29.4
Chandigarh			28.8	New Delhi		4.2	35.0
Chennai		10.6	37.2	Patna			34.0
Coimbatore		0.1	30.6	Port Blair		7.1	29.1
Dehradun		16.0	32.3	Prayagraj		1.6	35.5
Gangtok		38.0	23.7	Puducherry		36.6	25.7
Goa		7.1		Pune		0.5	28.3
Guwahati			34.0	Raipur			32.9
Hubballi			28.0	Ranchi			30.6
Hyderabad		0.1	32.4	Shillong			24.5
Imphal			30.3	Shimla		17.0	22.5
Jaipur		26.9		Srinagar		5.2	30.1
Kochi		82.6	29.6	Thiruvananthapuram		8.1	29.6
Kohima			34.4	Tiruchirappalli			35.7
Kolkata			34.4	Vijayawada			
Kozhikode		119.4	30.0	Visakhapatnam			32.8

CITIES	SO ₂	NO ₂	CO	PM _{2.5}	PM ₁₀	CODE	Yesterday
Ahmedabad		4	13	128		31	
Bengaluru		20	27	47		28	
Chennai		5	12		29	88	
Delhi		19	31	47	144	123	
Hyderabad		16	18	41	49	66	
Kolkata		17	22	52	85	101	
Lucknow		15	10	41	169	162	
Mumbai		4	4	39	46	59	
Pune		34	2	38	63	63	
Visakhapatnam		12	65	7	41	108	

Air Quality Code: ■ Poor ■ Moderate ■ Good (Readings indicate average AQI)
SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.
NO₂: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.
CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.
PM_{2.5} & PM₁₀: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

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FCARCSI, MRCA, DESA, DESRA, D.A.,
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TENDER Notice No. 2026472212303

The following e-tender is published in IREPS website. For details about Eligibility and other Terms & Conditions, please refer IREPS website www.ireps.gov.in. Manual offers will not be entertained for the tender.

Sl. No.	Tender Number	Name of the work	Date of Tender
			Closing Opening
1.	2026472212303	Supply, Installation and Commissioning of CAD Workstations at D&D Centre	21.08.2026 15.00 Hrs. 21.08.2026 After 15.00 Hrs.

INTEGRAL COACH FACTORY, CHENNAI - 38

Tender Notice No. 2026235212194R dt: 29.07.2026

The following e-tender is published in IREPS website. Firms are requested to login to www.ireps.gov.in and quote against the tender. Manual quotations will not be entertained for this tender.

Sl. No.	Open Tender No.	Short Description of the item	Tender Value (Rs.)	Last date of receipt / Date of opening of tender form
1.	2026235212194R	Complete wiring work in LSLRD / LSLRD (AB) / LVPH / LVCB (AB) coaches including handling & installation of equipment at ICF Chennai.	1,52,59,983.51	19.08.2026 15:00 Hrs.

Hindi version of the above Advertisement is available in ICF website: www.icf.indianrailways.gov.in/ Dy. Chief Electrical Engineer / Fur-II

INTEGRAL COACH FACTORY, CHENNAI - 38

The following e-tender is published in IREPS website. Firms are requested to login to www.ireps.gov.in and quote against the tender. Manual quotation will not be entertained for the tender.

Open Tender No.	Description of the item	Tender Value (Rs.)	Date of Tender Closing Date & Time
2026476212314	Works contract of 'Annual Maintenance Contract (AMC) for Maintaining Gas Storage Systems, Utility Gas supply Lines, MCG (LPG) Manifold and allied systems in LHB Division and maintaining gas storage system in ICF Hospital for three years.	98,42,651/-	20.08.2026 upto 15:00 Hours

Hindi version of the above Advertisement is available in ICF website: www.icf.indianrailways.gov.in Dy. Chief Mechanical Engineer / Plant

INTEGRAL COACH FACTORY, CHENNAI - 38

TENDER Notice No. ICF/EL/Cons/2026-27 dt. 03.08.2026

For and on behalf of The President of India, The Dy. Chief Electrical Engineer/ Maintenance/Shell, Integral Coach Factory, invites E - Tender for the following works.

Tender No.	Name of the Work	Approx. Value in Lakhs Rs.	EMD (Rupees)	Tender Closing Date and time
(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
2026245212317	EL-AMC-2026-27-28 Annual Maintenance Contract of Heavy-Duty Roof Extractor Fan installed at shell. Furnishing & LHB division for a period of three years.	64.07	1,28,200/-	26.08.2026 at 15.30 hrs.
2026245212235R	EL-W-938 Hiring of Public address System for Official / VIP Functions at ICF for a period of two years.	13.32	26,700/-	26.08.2026 at 15.30 hrs.

Website for submission of offer : www.ireps.gov.in
Hindi version of the above tender notification is available in: www.icf.indianrailways.gov.in

THE HINDU

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Port Blair - Rs. 20/-

INTEGRAL COACH FACTORY, CHENNAI - 38

Tender Notice No. ICF/PCMM/EOT/31/2026 Dated: 31.07.2026

The following e-tenders are published in IREPS website. Firms are requested to login to www.ireps.gov.in and quote against these tenders. Manual quotations will not be entertained for these tenders. Closing and Opening time for all tenders are 14.15 hrs. Hindi version of tender notice is available on website www.icf.indianrailways.gov.in

Sl. No.	Tender No.	Tender Title	Quantity	Due Date
01.	07262370B	SUPPLY OF C-MOULDING FOR LHB SCN COACHES	13788 Nos	04/08/2026
02.	07262343B	SUPPLY OF ONE NUMBER OF SS ROOF VENTILATOR GRILL ASSEMBLY	3630 Nos	04/08/2026
03.	06261624	S&I OF HT COMPT SS DOOR	194 Nos	14/08/2026
04.	06261625	S&I OF BIO RETENTION TANK FOR MEMU JK COACHES	210 Nos	17/08/2026
05.	06261773	S&I LUGGAGE RACK FOR LWSC22	3320 Nos	17/08/2026
06.	06261585	S&I OF RETENTION TANK / IGBT	791 Nos	18/08/2026
07.	06261562	SET OF IC DOOR	239 sets	19/08/2026
08.	03262146	ARTICULATION PIECE-FAB DESIGN CO	5609 Nos	20/08/2026
09.	08261628	150 SQMM CABLE SET FOR LHB C/S	567 Sets	20/08/2026
10.	03262055	SECONDARY LATERAL DAMPER FOR FIAT BOGIES WITH AIR SPRING	3105 Nos	21/08/2026
11.	03262013	UNF SS SHT 1X1250X3500MM AISI304	172394 Kgs	21/08/2026
12.	08261745	S&I ELEC CABLE TRAYS MEMU DMC 12	55 Sets	24/08/2026
13.	02261714	C/S of Frame work, Welding parts and Carline (VB Sleeper TC)	77 Sets	24/08/2026
14.	02260097	SUPPLY AND INSTALLATION OF NOSE CONE (EMU D)	30 Sets	24/08/2026
15.	02261718	C/S of Roof Assembly (VB Sleeper NDT)	18 Sets	24/08/2026
16.	03262015	WHEEL SET EARTHING EQUIPMENT TO RCF	2258 Sets	25/08/2026
17.	02261708	Coach Set of End Wall (VB Sleeper NDT)	18 Sets	25/08/2026
18.	03262148	160 KN AIR SPRING ASSEMBLY	1035 Sets	28/08/2026
19.	01265290	Self-Stackable Pallets to size 3200 x 2000 x 1420 mm	60 Nos	28/08/2026
20.	02261673	COACH SET OF ROOF DETAIL ITEMS (LWSC PP)	153 Sets	28/08/2026
21.	03261814	TRANSOM COMPLETE	1228 Nos	28/08/2026
22.	02261783	C/S OF ROOF SHEET (KM DTC)	30 Sets	31/08/2026
23.	02261722	C/S of Roof Assembly (VB Sleeper NDT)	18 Sets	31/08/2026
24.	02261717	C/S of Roof Assembly (VB Sleeper MC & NDT)	92 Sets	31/08/2026
25.	02261719	C/S of Roof Assembly (VB Sleeper TC)	111 Sets	31/08/2026

CORRIGENDUM NO. 31

Corrigendum has been issued to the following tender. Please check IREPS website for further details.

Sl.No.	Tender No.	Existing value	Modified value
01.	03261765	30/07/2026	13/08/2026
02.	03261849	29/07/2026	12/08/2026
03.	03261554	27/07/2026	06/08/2026
04.	06261775	28/07/2026	04/08/2026
05.	06263140A	30/07/2026	06/08/2026
06.	07265008	27/07/2026	04/08/2026
07.	07262259	27/07/2026	03/08/2026
Additions and Deletion of Special Eligibility Criteria. Please refer Tender Document for details in IREPS website.			
08.	07262261	27/07/2026	03/08/2026
Additions and Deletion of Special Eligibility Criteria and Drawing & Spec. Please refer Tender Document for details in IREPS website.			

EDUCATIONPLUS

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Sanil Raj Johnson

In February 2025, members of a peer-review team of the National Assessment and Accreditation Council (NAAC), including its chairman, were arrested by the CBI for allegedly accepting bribes to grant a top 'A++' grade to an institution. If accreditation, the very system meant to certify quality, can be compromised, then what are we truly measuring: institutional merit or institutional performance in staging merit?

What was once a quality assurance measure has, over time, developed into a kind of industry. Institutions now build dedicated teams – sometimes only for accreditation cycles – whose main job is to prepare for inspections, carefully organising activities to meet expected standards. What matters is whether they can be documented, formatted, and presented convincingly. This favours those who excel at presenting well over those who maintain genuine academic depth.

Too much documentation
At the heart of this transformation is the overwhelming dominance of documentation. The NAAC framework, with its multiple criteria – curriculum, teaching-learning, research, infrastructure, governance, and institutional values – requires extensive supporting documents. Faculty members are increasingly burdened with preparing reports, uploading evidence, and maintaining records.

Accreditation or academic illusion?

Nearly two decades into the accreditation and ranking systems for higher education, questions about their real impact continue



GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO

A well-documented activity becomes more valid than a meaningful but undocumented academic endeavour. This is in contrast to practices at institutions like the University of Michigan, the U.S., where the focus is on what students have learned, not on what institutions can project.

The issue worsens when accreditation influences rankings like those in the National Institutional Ranking Framework (NIRF), which depend heavily upon data provided by institutions themselves. Although verification systems exist, the recent scandal highlights their loopholes. If peer review can be manipulated, the trustworthiness of the entire ranking system is compromised.

Institutions, in turn, use

accreditation and rankings as marketing tools by prominently showcasing grades and positions to attract students. In this process, the line between authentic academic quality and strategic self-presentation becomes increasingly blurred.

International systems offer an entirely different approach. In the U.K., universities are assessed by the Quality Assurance Agency for Higher Education (QAA), which whether institutional activities genuinely promote student learning. Similarly, in Australia, the Tertiary Education Quality and Standards Agency (TEQSA) uses a risk-based approach.

Impact on faculty
As teachers become more engaged in documentation

and compliance, their interaction with students declines. Ongoing assessment, mentoring, and intellectual exchange are overshadowed by administrative tasks. This distortion is especially severe in India's uneven educational landscape.

Rural and under-resourced institutions, lacking basic infrastructure, are assessed using the same criteria as well-funded urban counterparts. Accreditation, instead of reducing inequality, often worsens it by favouring visibility and resources over context and effort.

Nearly two decades into operating accreditation and ranking systems, it is worth questioning their real impact. Has academic quality truly improved? Could students experience

meaningful learning? Or have institutions just become better at self-promotion? The National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 proposes a restructured accreditation framework that emphasises transparency, technology, and continuous evaluation. While these reforms are mandatory, they will fail if they simply digitise an existing over-bureaucratised system.

Accreditation must return to its core purpose: improving educational quality. This requires a clear shift from focusing on documentation to emphasising results, from valuing performance to emphasising substance, and from mere compliance to promoting creativity. Faculty should be liberated from excessive bureaucratic burdens and reconnected with their primary role as educators. Evaluation must become sensitive to context, acknowledging institutional differences along with providing fair and supportive measures.

Last year's scandal exposes a deeper systemic problem. When achievements can be staged, recorded, and even bought, accreditation becomes a false facade. For Indian higher education to regain its credibility, it must dismantle this illusion and create a system rooted in honesty, trust, and genuine learning.

Views expressed are personal

The writer is a Professor of English and Dean of Student Affairs, Sahridaya College of Advanced Studies (Autonomous), Thrissur, Kerala. Email: saniljohn03@gmail.com

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CM YK M CH-CE



Perhaps guided by forecasts of a deficient monsoon, Karnataka's Chief Minister chose to err on the side of caution, anticipating an acute drinking water shortage ahead. However, this has proved costly for Tamil Nadu, which realised only about 3.6 tmc ft from June 1 to July-end, barely 10% of the 40-odd tmc ft prescribed by the Cauvery Water Disputes Tribunal and the Supreme Court. The Cauvery Water Management Authority (CWMA), at its July 30 meeting, ratified the Cauvery Water Regulation Committee (CWRC)'s directive that Karnataka release 3,500 cusecs to Billigundulu daily for 15 days from July 29. Although this quantum would not have met irrigation needs in Tamil Nadu's Cauvery delta, it would have provided some support to the ecosystem. The CWMA's decision has upset farmers in Karnataka and the political class but nature has intervened in a limited way. If Karnataka finds the existing mechanisms – the CWMA and CWRC – inadequate, it can suggest alternatives, but must first abide by the decisions of these institutions, which safeguard riparian States' interests in line with Tribunal and Supreme Court verdicts. Unlike his predecessors, Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay reached out to his Karnataka counterpart, D.K. Shivakumar – but Mr. Shivakumar has asked Mr. Vijay to defer his August 3 Bengaluru visit. However, this episode should not deter the two States from making a renewed bid to work out a distress-sharing formula, the last of which was attempted nearly 25 years ago. Mr. Vijay should also take a cue from his counterpart in handling the Cauvery issue, by bringing together other political players in the State.

In September 2020, the Bhiwandi Municipal Corporation in Maharashtra placed the Kohinoor building on its 'danger' list around the same time the Jilani building collapsed a few kilometres away, killing 41. Six years on, and hours after officials declared the Kohinoor to be unsafe again and evacuated around 40 residents, it collapsed, killing 10. In the half decade in between, the owners had refused to vacate or redevelop the property and instead undertook unauthorised repairs. While the fall of the Jilani building, which was old but not on a 'dangerous' list, was a failure of anticipation, that of the Kohinoor building, on such a list and which fell mid-repairs, implies a failure of enforcement. Yet, the State responded similarly in both instances, by suspending officials in 2020 and filing a criminal case against the contractor now. Bhiwandi, one of India's largest powerloom hubs, has a large low-income migrant population living in small houses in densely packed neighbourhoods. With hundreds of buildings on the 'danger' list and no transit camps or temporary housing, residents often choose unsafe homes over homelessness, while owners continue collecting rent. Evacuation orders are also hard to enforce without police support, while allowing the corporation to claim that legal liability has been discharged on paper; demolitions are politically fraught. That both buildings collapsed during the monsoons is also not coincidental.

India treats infrastructure as an asset with a one-time investment. The post-2000s construction boom only outpaced maintenance work and administrative oversight, with the latter having fragmented further since. In mid-2024, roofs/canopies collapsed at airports in Delhi, Jabalpur, and Rajkot while Bihar had a spate of collapsing bridges in 2024-26. Roads have frequently caved in and basements have flooded in tier-1 cities, including in the Rajinder Nagar tragedy. This year, similar collapses have also been reported in Kolkata and Pune. Despite the availability of technologies to continuously monitor structures and issue early warnings, urbanisation has outrun municipal capacity, with most of the resulting failures involving a known hazard. The apparent rise in the frequency of these incidents indicates a lack of attention to construction quality as much as greater media coverage and there being more infrastructure to fail. But in place of the state's almost instinctive responses in the form of legal and disciplinary action, inquiries and promises of audits, and victim compensation, India's buildings need widespread rehabilitation work. Nothing short of an urban renewal would do.

Fifty years ago, in the winter and monsoon of 1976, two states on two continents were teaching the opposite lesson in real time. On June 16, schoolchildren in Soweto, South Africa, who marched against the imposition of Afrikaans as the medium of instruction were met with live ammunition; hundreds died in the weeks that followed. In India, the Emergency had already emptied the campuses by other means: student unions stood suspended, and activists of every persuasion sat in jail under the Maintenance of Internal Security Act (MISA). Pretoria used bullets, New Delhi used preventive detention, and both were confident they had restored order. Within a decade and a half, the generation of Soweto had made apartheid ungovernable, and the generation of the Emergency had produced much of India's post-1977 political leadership. Order purchased through the suppression of the young turned out to be the most expensive commodity either state ever bought.

This July, the streets around Parliament and Jantar Mantar have supplied the third panel of the triptych. What began as an online satire has become one of the largest student mobilisations in years, built on grievances that are neither manufactured nor abstract: a leaked National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (Undergraduate), or NEET-UG, paper that forced the cancellation of an undergraduate medical examination taken by over 20 lakh aspirants, and an on-screen marking controversy that left thousands of school students in limbo. So far, the state's response has followed the familiar pattern of barricades, tear gas, a baton charge that injured more than 100 students during the march on Parliament, and rhetoric from the highest levels of the establishment comparing protesters to vermin.



From 1876 to 2026, student grievances expose failures of governance

The politics of disrespect

Lesson two: contempt delegitimises the state faster than it delegitimises the students. The colonial government's error in 1876 was not primarily one of policy. It was one of register. By treating the civil service age question as beneath serious engagement, it told an entire educated generation that their aspirations had no standing before the state. Banerjee understood that the insult was more mobilising than the injury, and the Indian Association was built on that understanding.

The instinct to belittle is alive today. When constitutional functionalities such as the Chief Justice of India reach for the vocabulary of pest control to describe a section of youth, they repeat the Raj's mistake with less excuse. Dehumanising language aimed at the young does not shrink a movement but hands the movement its identity, its symbols and its moral high ground in a single gesture. The protesters outside Parliament this week did not have to manufacture the charge that the state holds them in contempt. The state made the charge for them, on the record. A government serious about de-escalation would begin not with concessions but with a change of register by acknowledging, plainly and publicly, that the integrity of public examinations is a legitimate constitutional concern of every citizen who sits

for one, and that those raising it are stakeholders, not enemies.

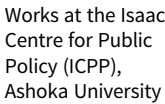
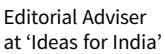
Lesson three: protest is the symptom; blocked accountability is the disease. Students do not camp on pavements because they enjoy tear gas. They do so when every institutional channel for redress has been tried and found closed. The 1976 agitation arose because Indians had no representative forum in which the civil service rules could even be debated and the Association became the forum the constitution did not provide. The Emergency-era campuses went silent because the ordinary machinery of accountability, the courts, the press, the legislature, had been suspended; when it was restored in 1977, the verdict was unambiguous.

The Gen Z-led education reform movement has been explicit that it wants action rather than assurances: credible investigations, examination reform, and accountability for the institutional failures that preceded the leak. These are demands that a functioning system of parliamentary and regulatory oversight should have been capable of processing without a single barricade. The durable answer to this protest is therefore not a better crowd-control strategy but a stronger accountability architecture, wherein an examination authority enjoys genuine independence, evaluation and reevaluation are subject to statutory transparency, parliamentary committee scrutiny produces published findings, and consequences attach to officials rather than only to investigators and middlemen. A state that builds those channels makes the street redundant. A state that refuses to build them makes the street inevitable.

It is an accident of the calendar, but a useful one, that the July 2026 crackdown falls in the same week as the sesquicentenary of the Indian Association. The men who governed India in 1876 could not have imagined that a students' grievance about an examination would seed the movement that ended their rule. Public officials who governed India and South Africa in 1976 could not have imagined that the teenagers they jailed and shot would inherit their states. No government ever believes the pattern applies to itself. That is precisely how the pattern survives.

The young people at Jantar Mantar were not asking the state to surrender. They were asking it to be worthy of the examinations it conducts. On the evidence of a century and a half, the governments that listen to that request are the ones that last.

The discourse on building strong public health systems tends to start with financing. Indeed, according to the World Bank, the per capita public spending on universal health coverage in low- and middle-income countries (LMICs) – including government expenditure and off-budget development assistance – is about half of the minimum benchmarks. As a share of gross domestic product (GDP), the health expenditure gap between LMICs and high-income countries narrowed from 2.05 percentage points in 2000 to 1.68 percentage points in 2023. While it may seem that LMICs are “catching up”, recent World Health Organization data show that in per capita terms the gap has in fact expanded more than three-fold during this period.



With foreign aid cuts and strained domestic budgets, the way forward may be to spend available money better

debt leaving less for other needs including health. With public sources drying up, it is unlikely that more money will flow into health systems anytime soon and the way forward may be to spend available money better. There are three broad ways to make public health spending go further.

The first is to spend what is allocated. The World Bank reports that health budgets in LMICs are executed at around 85%-90%, rates that are lower than that for the general budget and for education. This effectively means that there is a deprioritisation of health at the implementation stage of budgets. In India, a parliamentary panel found that only about two-thirds of the allocation for the flagship health infrastructure mission was spent in 2024-25. Within the National Health Mission (NHM), the picture is worse: just 26% of the money earmarked for communicable and non-communicable disease programmes was actually used that year.

The second is to spend on the right things. Budget execution varies across expenditure categories. While wages and salary budgets tend to be implemented in full, there is underspending on goods and services. As a result, workers are not well-equipped to deliver quality health care. More broadly, there is a choice to be made in terms of the tiers of health care that are prioritised in public spending. A lot of the money goes to curative care at the secondary and tertiary levels – at the cost of preventive, primary health care. According to estimates from the London School of Hygiene & Tropical Medicine, India spends less than one-fourth of public health money on preventive care.

Purely from a health impact viewpoint, public health money is best spent on classic public goods such as infectious disease control or sanitation, where there is a ‘market failure’ – rather than on the expansion of relatively cheap curative health services (for instance, treating common illnesses) that the private sector is

already supplying competitively. Recent evidence bears this out: public health spending markedly improves infectious disease outcomes, through greater access, vaccination, and sanitation, but does far less for maternal and child health or non-communicable diseases, making a strong case for strategic allocation. As populations age, more will need to be done for chronic conditions in terms of addressing risk factors, early detection, and management.

The third is to improve governance and operational efficiency. Good governance is key: if corruption is reduced or the quality of bureaucracy improves, countries see greater positive effects of public health spending on desired health outcomes, such as child mortality. The converse also holds: simply increasing spending where governance is weak is unlikely to improve outcomes. Moreover, with the increasing decentralisation of public service delivery, it is becoming imperative to focus on improving governance at the subnational level.

Within governance, there is a crucial role for public finance management. While a well-formulated budget is a good starting point, impact will only be achieved if the budget is implemented efficiently. There is a need to improve budget credibility and cash disbursement. Involvement of public health providers in budget processes can enhance both their accountability and motivation. Improving procurement processes can help achieve greater value for money in health sector resources. As the pandemic has taught us, budgets should be flexible to respond to unforeseen circumstances.

That said, the case for enhanced spending remains: its returns are greatest precisely where health outcomes are poorest; hence, money that is well-directed can help narrow gaps across countries.

Both writers co-author 'The Care Gap', a living literature review supported by Coefficient Giving

Ayurveda and reform

The National Commission for Indian System of Medicine (NCISM), Government of India, recently issued a circular stating that those who denigrate ayurvedic degree holders as quacks or fake doctors would invite statutory action. It is certainly uncouth to hurl vile insults at people who undergo a five-year course fully recognised and endorsed by the same universities that grant MBBS

degrees. As such, the NCISM is justified in issuing the statement. However, more fundamentally, the NCISM should introspect on why the professionals it creates and endorses are being called quacks. There are serious problems in the way ayurveda is approached, taught, and studied. A lack of timely, evidence-informed revisions has fossilised ayurvedic theories, which in turn has impeded a straightforward appraisal of its practices.

Together, these factors have made a significant portion of the ayurveda degree syllabus pseudoscientific. The NCISM's recent mistakes, such as treating Indian philosophy as being close to quantum mechanics or introducing medical astrology as an elective subject, have worsened the situation. The NCISM must understand the ayurvedic dictum that "eliminating the cause of a disease is the sum and substance of all treatment".

Unless there is serious introspection and a radical overhaul of the approach to ayurvedic studies, the NCISM will spend its time on futile statutory manoeuvres.

Dr. G.L. Krishna,
Bengaluru

K. Jamuna Rani
Even before music lovers could come to terms with the demise of the legendary playback singer S. Janaki, South Indian film music has lost another iconic veteran,

K. Jamuna Rani, whose voice was more than just a part of cinema; it became a treasured memory for millions of listeners. She collaborated with some of the greatest music directors and sang over 6,000 songs across multiple languages, including Tamil, Telugu, Kannada, Malayalam, and Sinhalese. Renowned for her distinct folk flavour, rhythmic vitality, and memorable duets, she left an indelible mark on South Indian film music. Her

timeless solos and duets, including 'Paatondru Ketter Paravasamanen', 'Kaalai Vayasu Kattana Saisu', 'Yaaradi Nee Mohini', 'Athikkai Kaali Kaai', and 'Kungumapoove Konjum Purave', will remain forever woven into the fabric of our memories.

R. Sivakumar,
Chennai

Letters emailed to
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must carry the full postal
address and the full name or
the name with initials.

Analysing the SC’s judgment on sex work

For more than three decades, sex workers have told governments and courts how anti-trafficking interventions cause profound harm including forced rescues, indefinite detention in “corrective homes”, separation from children and even threat to life. And for decades, these accounts were only acknowledged in fragments, and never in a comprehensive rights-based framework. That is what makes the Supreme Court’s judgment of May 29, 2026, so significant.

Across nearly 300 pages, the court departs from many assumptions that have long shaped anti-trafficking discourse globally. It recognises that agency and vulnerability can coexist; rejects the conflation of migration with trafficking; affirms that constitutional rights do not disappear because society disapproves of sex work; holds that consenting adult sex workers cannot forcibly be rescued; and that any intervention must begin with an inquiry into consent. Invoking Article 142, the court gives these directions legal force.

But the judgment also exposes a paradox: it adopts arguments that have been painstakingly developed by sex workers but does not acknowledge the workers or their collectives (such as the National Network of Sex Workers among others). This is not only a question of credit; it reveals how even progressive jurisprudence can reproduce a hierarchy of knowledge in which those most affected by law remain its least recognised authors.

What the judgment assumes
The judgment places faith in institutions that have repeatedly failed the very people it seeks to protect. The court assumes that clearer legal standards will produce different institutional behaviour – that police officers will assess consent without prejudice, magistrates will suspend moral judgment, shelter homes will become rights-based



Pankhuri Agarwal
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Sex workers and their unions must move from the margins to the centre of implementation. They should draft guidelines, monitor compliance, shape police training, and establish standards for shelters

support services, and sex workers will have access to legal aid. For many women, especially those from the Dalit and Adivasi communities, bureaucracy has never been a neutral system. Caste discrimination and economic marginalisation continue to shape everyday encounters with the state. One woman, wrongly labelled a trafficker after a raid, has spent seven years reporting every month to a police station while attending court hearings where, despite all this time, her statement has never even been recorded. “I go to court and sit outside. Then they call my name, and I go inside. But they don’t ask me anything. They have not even recorded my statement yet!”

The top court rightly recognises caste as one of the structural conditions that can push women into sex work. But it stops there. Caste does not simply explain entry into the profession. It also structures every institution responsible for implementing this judgment. As one worker put it: “The state says that *acche din* (good days) will come. When will our *acche din* come? Everything is about money these days. Take any actor. They can kill but do not get arrested. Those who do not have money have to keep going to the court like me.” Her question exposes the judgment’s central assumption: that the law is applied equally once rights are recognised. For many workers, the challenge is not only overcoming moral prejudice. It is navigating a legal and bureaucratic system that continues to be shaped by caste.

The judgment is also noticeably quieter about another source of violence: the anti-trafficking industry itself. The court recommends reforming shelter homes but does not examine the organisations that run them, the funding structures that sustain them, or the incentives that make carceral and forced rescue practices persist. The rescue industry is not solely a humanitarian project. It is sustained by a dense network of

civil society organisations that participate in forced raids, manage shelter homes, and exercise significant authority over the women confined within them. One woman who experienced both prison and a government shelter offered a striking comparison. “Even after rescue, we are bound by the shelter. It is another form of bondage. It seems better to serve six months in jail and come out free than to stay in a shelter for an unknown time.” This account is not an exception. It exposes an uncomfortable reality that anti-trafficking discourse obscures: rescue can become another mechanism of control.

The road ahead
The top Court’s recommendations are important. But for the judgment to fulfil its promise, three priorities stand out. First, sex workers and their unions must move from the margins to the centre of implementation. They should draft guidelines, monitor compliance, shape police training, and establish standards for shelters. Second, the anti-trafficking NGO sector deserves scrutiny. Longstanding evidence suggests that some have become active participants in coercive rescue practices while operating with limited accountability to the communities they claim to serve. Their funding and legal immunity should no longer be taken for granted. Finally, the structural conditions identified by the court do not require new institutions to fix. India already possesses an extensive welfare architecture. The challenge is ensuring that sex workers can access it as rights-bearing citizens. The Supreme Court has opened an important constitutional door. Whether it leads to meaningful change will depend on whether India’s institutions can abandon decades of paternalism and begin treating sex workers as citizens whose choices deserve the same legal respect as anyone else’s.

Bengaluru’s civic woes

It remains to be seen whether clearance drives will lead to long-term solutions

STATE OF PLAY

K.C. Deepika

Over the last month, residents of Bengaluru have witnessed the Karnataka government waking up to some age-old problems such as encroached footpaths, garbage blackspots, footpath riding and the like.

Spearheaded by the new Greater Bengaluru Development Minister, Krishna Byre Gowda, back-to-back drives since July 1 saw civic authorities attempt to reclaim the city’s notoriously bad pedestrian infrastructure from encroachments by commercial establishments, street vendors, abandoned vehicles, and garbage dumps – problems that most residents had simply resigned to live with.

Though citizens have welcomed the drives, street vendors argue that they were never given vending zones. Moreover, garbage dumping and blackspots exist mostly due to inefficient waste collection as well as civic apathy. In some cases, dumping is carried out by the civic workers themselves due to the lack of waste transfer stations.

The drive to clear footpaths in the city led to altercations between street vendors and civic authorities; in one such clearance drive in Shivajinagar, miscreants even attacked the officials carrying out the drive. Citizens also reported that several of the encroachments that were cleared were back to how they were days after the clearance drive.

The Minister maintained that the aim was not to displace anyone but to create safe pedestrian infrastructure at least on the arterial roads; he said that vendors could move to the inner roads to



continue business. However, street vendor unions have questioned this logic, pointing to the lack of will by successive governments to streamline street vending by assigning ID cards and notifying vending zones, so as to prevent harassment from anti-social elements and enforcement agencies. Mr. Gowda later directed corporation officials to conduct a fresh survey of street vendors as the previous survey had enumerated only a little over 30,000 street vendors, while the actual number exceeds 80,000. He also instructed them to identify vending zones.

In the case of abandoned vehicles, the Minister clarified that the campaign is not aimed at vehicles in regular use, admitting that parking regulations requiring houses to have dedicated parking spaces had not been enforced for decades, resulting in residents having to park their vehicles on public roads.

Lack of planning
Urban planning experts and residents have repeatedly pointed to one lacuna when it comes to Bengaluru: the lack of a long-term vision that can keep pace with the level of growth the city experiences. This, they have argued, applies to many areas, from planning the Namma Metro network, that is yet to reach the Kempegowda International Airport, to ensuring con-

nectivity to Bengaluru’s rapidly expanding boundaries. To address what is easily the city’s best claim to infamy, its traffic, the Congress Government has pushed for new tunnel roads and flyovers. However, urban experts and citizens’ groups have continuously argued against them, reasoning that the city’s public transport should be strengthened instead of introducing short-term solutions for the growing number of private vehicles. Another case in point is the city’s way of addressing its water needs. As Bengaluru’s once famed network of lakes has been undermined by infrastructure projects, the government is focussed on bringing solutions from afar. Every drought-hit year threatens the Cauvery dependent-city’s water security. The State government, under the leadership of the new Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar, is pushing aggressively for the positioning of Bengaluru as a prime investment destination. As Bengaluru continues to function without an elected civic council since 2020, with the State government facing pressure from the Supreme Court to conduct elections this year, the emphasis on mega projects such as tunnel roads is being seen as an attempt to tilt the odds towards the Congress. But since there is no assurance on when these big-ticket projects would be realised, the slew of new drives to fix basic pedestrian problems are the ones that could provide instant relief to citizens. There is a growing call for the government to improve the quality of life of the citizens by first fixing the basics before moving on to big-ticket projects.

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Europe’s relentless summer leads to unprecedented wildfires

France and Spain have been the most affected so far, with the area affected in the former this year already surpassing record levels since 1980

DATA POINT

Nitika Francis
Devyanshi Bihani

With at least a month left for summer to end in most of Europe, some of the countries, which were already affected by heat wave conditions this year, are now facing wildfires at a pace unseen in the recent past.

France and Spain are the most affected. As of last week, 91,209 hectares have been destroyed by wildfires in France, which already surpasses the total area burned due to forest fires in the country in a year at least since 1980.

As per the Forest Fires in Europe, Middle East and North Africa 2024 report brought out by the Joint Research Centre (JRC) of the European Commission, 75,566 hectares of land which got burnt in 1989 was the previous record.

The extent of the impact of the wildfires is likely to go up significantly in France in the coming days. **Chart 1** shows the area burnt due to forest fires in France in the past decade, as per the European Forest Fire Information System (EFFIS).

The effects of climate change
The heat wave conditions and the forest fires are seen as symptomatic of Europe’s rising temperatures, attributed to climate change.

The fire in the Bordeaux region is shaping up to be the biggest forest fire France has seen. According to multiple media reports, the fire has already burnt through 42,000 hectares of pine forest, destroyed 240 homes, spread close to densely populated areas, with the smoke reaching up to 400 km away.

This has also led to the highest number of people who have been shifted in a single instance to safe locations due to natural disasters. According to the *Associated Press*, more than 2.2 lakh people have been temporarily relocated. Data

show that the Bordeaux fire displaced more people than those displaced in wildfires over the past five years combined, which amounts to about 61,000 persons, as per the Internal Displacement Monitoring Centre (**Table 1**).

The total cumulative annual carbon emissions of the 2026 fires – 300 kilotonnes of carbon – has already surpassed the extreme emissions recorded in 2022 and 2003, according to the World Weather Association (WWA).

The area burnt due to wildfires in the European Union from the beginning of June till June 29, 2026 has already exceeded the total area affected by wildfires over the last 10 years (**Chart 2**). Spain is also witnessing widespread destruction. Around 1.9 lakh hectares of land has been burnt in Spain since June, which is the second highest since 2022.

According to the WWA, the most severe fires are in southwestern France and central and eastern Spain. The map shows the regions affected by forest fires in France this year compared to the previous year. The report of the WWA states that the affected area in France and Spain received above-average rainfall in the winter, which led to the promotion of vegetation growth. These conditions were followed by record-high temperatures, which depleted soil moisture and increased water stress in shrubs and pine trees. These conditions increased the likelihood of the rapid spread of wildfires.

Europe has become the world’s fastest-warming continent outside the Arctic. Average temperatures over successive decades show Europe moving from 1.08 degree Celsius below the 1991-2020 average in the decade ending 1955 to 0.87 degree Celsius above it in the decade ending 2025. During the same period, Europe warmed faster than every other continent except the Arctic, outpacing Asia, North America, Africa and the global average.



TABLE 1: Number of internally displaced persons (IDPs) due to wildfires in France. The 2026 figures only represent the persons displaced in the Bordeaux region

Year	Number of IDPs due to wildfires
2017	7,300
2018	682
2019	548
2020	3,010
2021	8,000
2022	44,556
2023	3,313
2024	142
2025	2,476
2026	2,24,000*

*According to an Associated Press report. The 2026 figure is more than three times the total of the previous nine years

CHART 1: This shows the area burnt in wildfire incidents in France since 2017. The blaze in the Bordeaux region alone accounted for more than 50% of the area burnt in 2026

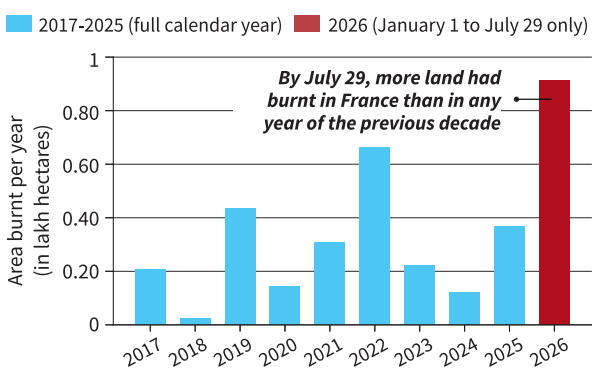
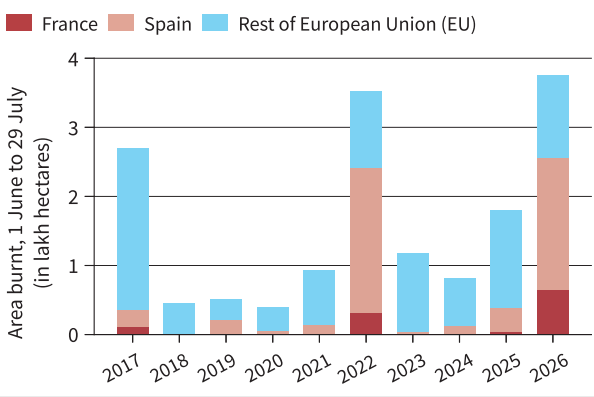
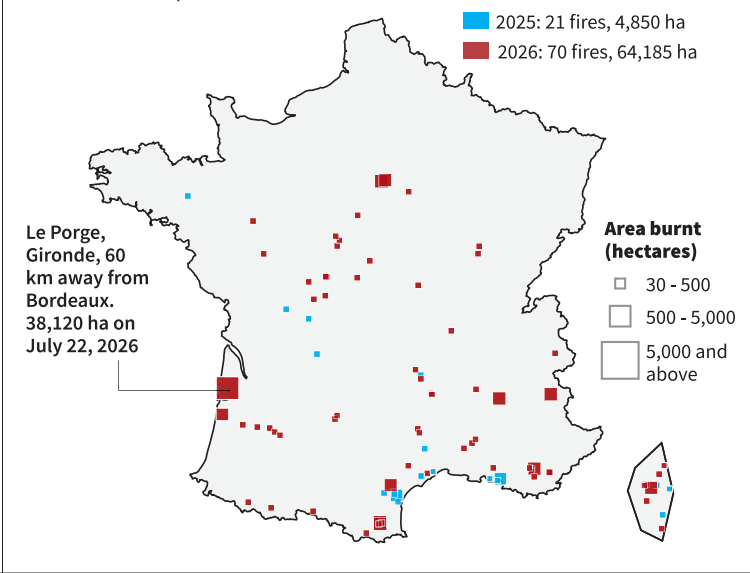


CHART 2: This shows the area burnt across the EU due to wildfires from June till end of July every year. The destruction in Spain is similar to 2022, while that in France is its worst ever



MAP 1: Each square represents a wildfire incident in the June to July period. The size of the square is indicative of the area burnt in the incident



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO AUGUST 3, 1976

5 tmcft. of water released to help Tamil Nadu

Bangalore, August 2: Karnataka is giving five tmcft. of water to Tamil Nadu as a ‘gesture of goodwill’ to save the kuruvai crop in Thanjavur delta.

The decision was taken this morning by the Chief Minister, Mr. D. Deveraj Urs, in response to a request from Tamil Nadu.

The Karnataka authorities started releasing water in the afternoon. The water is expected to reach Mettur Dam in the next two days. A spokesman of the Karnataka Government said that water was being released purely as a gesture of goodwill in spite of Karnataka’s own difficulties. He pointed out that the situation in South Karnataka was bad and the standing crop, particularly sugarcane crop in the Krishnarajasagar ayacut, had suffered badly because of lack of water. The State Government was experiencing difficulty in providing adequate water to save the standing crop. The rainfall so far had been the lowest Karnataka had received in recent years.

Madras, August 2: The decision of the Karnataka Government to release five tmc feet of water from Krishnarajasagar has been welcomed by Tamil Nadu officials who were worried over the fast depleting storage in Mettur where the inflow has reached a mere 10 cusecs this morning.

They are happy that Karnataka has come to Tamil Nadu’s rescue at this moment when water is urgently required for Kuruvai cultivation in Thanjavur district.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO AUGUST 3, 1926

Anglo-Indian association

Quetta, August 3: The Quetta branch of the Anglo-Indian and domiciled European Association has been resuscitated by Mr. Lawrence P. Atkinson, travelling Secretary, who addressed a meeting at the Baluchi Club on July 30, Rev. J. Cummings presiding. Mr. Atkinson said that it was imperative that the Anglo-Indian community should take their stand with the other communities in India as a combined minority. He appealed for support to Col. Gidney’s fund for the higher education of the community. A successful dance was given to meet the travelling Secretary at the Railway Institute on the night of August 2.

SIT probe into Ram Temple case a sham, says Congress

Rahul criticises Modi, says government owes students truth, justice and apology

Slipper hurled at MP who took part in Ram Temple skit; one held

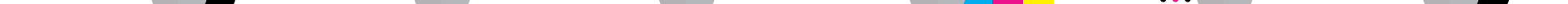
Gen Z is a constituency defined by mindset, not identity, says strategist

Channi supporters raise slogans at Congress event as infighting continues

Fadnavis likely to be made Education Minister, claims Raut

Raj Thackeray says ₹18 crore siphoned off from temple

Users protest after YouTube terminates slum-dweller's page

CM YK  M CH-CHE

After four straight months of selling, foreign investors turned net buyers of Indian equities in July, pumping in ₹20,200 crore, aided by attractive valuations, improving corporate earnings, and easing global headwinds. The latest inflow marks a sharp reversal from the preceding months when Foreign Portfolio Investors (FPIs) withdrew ₹49,340 crore in June, ₹32,963 crore in May, ₹60,847 crore in April, and a massive ₹1.17 lakh crore in March, according to data from the Central Depository Services (India) Ltd. (CDSL). Prior to the four-month selling spree, the FPIs had invested ₹22,615 crore in Indian equities in February. PTI

A court has granted bail to five accused in the sexual harassment and forcible conversion case at the Nashik unit of IT major TCS, observing that the chargesheet has been filed and investigation was practically complete. The court allowed the pleas of Raza Rafiq Memon, Asif Aftab Ansari, Shahrukh Hussain Shaukat Qureshi, Shafi Bhikan Shaikh and Tausif Bilal Attar on July 30. They were granted bail in connection with multiple FIRs registered at Mumbai Naka police station in Nashik. The court also said there was no serious apprehension that the accused would threaten witnesses or tamper with evidence if released.

Gold and silver lacked lustre in July

PRECIOUS METALS



Lose sheen: War, U.S. rate issues influenced the prices of precious metals in July. REUTERS

B. Krishnakumar

Precious metals were confined to a very narrow range and remained subdued for the best part of July. The geopolitical developments in West Asia along with the concerns relating to a potential interest rate hike in the United States kept the prices of precious metals under check. Price of gold witnessed some recovery toward the end of July after the U.S. Federal Reserve kept the interest rates unchanged.

Gain and hit Comex gold posted a modest 1.7% gain in July to settle at \$4,107 by the end of month. In contrast to gold, Comex silver price took a modest 3.6% hit in July to settle at \$57.75.

Mirroring the trend in the global markets, the precious metal prices took a hit in domestic markets too. MCX Gold fell 1.71% in July to settle at ₹1,43,376 per 10-gram. MCX Silver too closed on a weak note at ₹2,17,198 per kilogram, a 4.6% fall last month.

Comex gold price was confined to \$3,949-\$4,215 range in July. There is no change in the short-term negative outlook for gold that was shared last month. Gold price is vulnerable to drop to \$3,750-\$3,850 range.

As observed last month, the trend will remain weak unless the price closes above \$4,410. Above \$4,410, the trend could turn positive, and the price could head to the next upside target of \$4,650-\$4,700. But, until this breakout above \$4,410 happens, expect the gold price to drift lower to the target zone of \$3,750-\$3,850.

Comex silver price moved in sync with last month's expectations and the price also dropped to the then mentioned support zone at \$54-\$56. The short-term outlook for silver does not look positive and the price has to cross above \$66 to invalidate this outlook. In the short-term, expect the price to remain subdued and drift lower to \$52-\$54 range.

As observed last month, the trend in MCX gold price has turned negative too. The gold price at MCX dropped to the then-mentioned target level of ₹1,35,000-₹1,40,000 range. The short-term outlook remains weak and the price could now drop to ₹1,32,000-₹1,35,000 zone. This view would be invalidated if the price moves above ₹1,49,000. Similar to gold, the trend in MCX silver price too is bearish and the price now is vulnerable to a slide to ₹1,99,000-₹2,05,000 in the near term. Only a breakout above ₹2,45,000 would invalidate this negative view.

Conclusion

To summarise, the short-term trend in gold and silver are negative post the breach of key support levels in June. The trend would remain weak until the resistance level mentioned above is not taken out.

(The author is a Chennai based analyst / trader. The views and opinion featured in this column is based on the analysis of short-term price movement in gold and silver futures at COMEX & Multi Commodity Exchange of India. This is not meant to be a trading or investment advice.)

Send queries on personal finance and investing to the moneywise@thehindu.co.in ID. Our experts in personal finance will respond to select queries, but will not give specific recommendations for investment in a particular mutual fund, share or fixed deposit.

MONEYWISE



ILLUSTRATION: SAAI

Take dedicated insurance cover for your travel

Most travellers assume they covered their bases once they buy the standard travel cover; when it comes to risks specific to adventure sports, dedicated cover will protect against them

FULLY COVERED

Amit Chhabra

Helen Keller famously said - 'Life is either a daring adventure or nothing at all.'

Seasoned travellers can relate to this. But there's something else they know. When you choose adventure, you also choose the risks coming along with it. Not every adventure might end in an adrenaline rush. Some adventures also end up turning into accidents. And when they do, there ought to be a back-up plan or at the very least, a protective shield. Most travellers assume they covered their bases once they buy the standard travel cover. When it comes to risks specific to adventure sports, dedicated cover will protect against them.

As per several international travel health reports, injury is the single biggest cause of emergency hospitalisation for healthy people crossing international borders. Our own data notes out of the total number of travel cover claims, more than 60% is due to medical and related reasons. In fact, the breakdown of claim amounts shows medical emergencies account for almost 90% of the total payout with the rest for non-medical reasons. Clearly, health emergencies tend to overshadow every other risk here.

Imagine weeks of planning your great escape only to be blindsided by a

Standard travel cover is built for situations such as flight delays or an unexpected medical emergency. It draws a clear line between routine travel mishaps and higher-risk pursuits

medical crisis that a standard travel insurance usually won't cover. However, it doesn't have to turn out this way. Here's what you should know.

Gamble before thrills

People meticulously plan itineraries and book activities but overlook the fine print of what insurance covers or doesn't cover. Standard travel cover is built for conventional situations such as flight delays, lost baggage or an unexpected medical emergency. It draws a clear line between routine travel mishaps and higher-risk pursuits. This is especially true if the plan is bought bundled along with tickets.

This leaves activities such as high altitude mountain sports, deep-sea diving and aerial adventures outside the scope of standard cover unless additional protection has been purchased in advance. The surprise actually comes when a claim is declined. Depending on the plan, there might be further differentiation between recreational activities and extreme sports, or imposing altitude limits, age restrictions and norms

An undisclosed adventure activity or an inaccurate declaration while taking insurance can render the whole exercise meaningless; so, make sure you declare everything needed

the activity be undertaken under certified supervision. These need to be taken into account before you go diving, hiking or climbing.

Only few extra bucks

If you plan to go for an adventure sport, you should check if your base plan offers the cover or you need to buy it as add-on. Consider a week-long overseas trip costing about ₹2.5-3 lakh. Your total premium will cost anywhere from ₹1,000-₹1,600. That small addition is what could save you hundreds of thousands of rupees you might end up spending on a hospital in a foreign country.

An emergency helicopter evacuation from a remote trekking route or ski resort can run into lakhs before the treatment even begins. Add surgery, intensive care or a specialist consultation in destinations such as the UK, Switzerland or New Zealand, and the final bill can climb several times higher. In the unfortunate case that your trip is disrupted by a mishap during a high-risk sport, this rider can provide coverage for emergency medical treatment,

evacuation, accidental disability or death from covered activities, and more such expenses that can otherwise escalate into a full scale financial setback.

For about five extra minutes of time, you can understand how critical this addition is to the policy and protect against expenses that may otherwise eclipse the cost of the entire holiday.

Better preparation

For many, collecting experiences has now become more valuable than collecting souvenirs. Insurance has had to keep pace with that change. It is evolving from a generic safeguard into a product that can accommodate increasingly diverse ways of exploring the world. That evolution matters because the purpose of insurance is to ensure that one unforeseen moment does not end up defining an entire journey.

The purpose of this critical addition is to strengthen the traveller's economic confidence.

But even the most comprehensive policy has one non-negotiable requirement – transparency. An undisclosed adventure activity or an inaccurate declaration can render the whole exercise meaningless. So, make sure you declare everything that is needed. As travel becomes more experiential, insurance should be measured by how well it matches the risks that you as an individual choose to embrace.

(The writer is Chief Business Officer, General Insurance, Policybazaar)

Satellite portfolio to the rescue

THINKINVESTOR

Transferring from satellite to a core portfolio will reduce trading capital. You can transfer the amount from the core back to the satellite once you create buffer capital in the core portfolio

Venkatesh Bangaruswamy

In a core-satellite framework, the core portfolio relates to goal-based investments while satellite portfolio captures short-term price movements in the market. Here, we discuss the benefits of having satellite portfolio alongside your core portfolios.

Managing gains

The satellite portfolio is about market timing. Actively buying and selling ETFs and individual stocks, for instance. There are two benefits from managing a satellite portfolio. Suppose you buy a stock at ₹500 and sell it at ₹700. There is the pleasure of generating gains. Suppose the stock dips after you sell it. The emotional satisfaction of perfectly timing the market is profound though you may realise luck played an important role in the process. This pleasure of generating gains does not diminish even if you self-manage your satellite portfolio for many years.

What do you with the gains from the satellite portfolio? Often, we reinvest the proceeds into the satellite portfolio, confident about market timing. But it pays to hold some gains and invest in bank deposits.

You can plough back the proceeds into the satellite portfolio when you incur losses. Also, you can use these funds and some from the satellite portfolio to manage any shortfall in your core portfolio. That is the second benefit.

Suppose one of your core portfolios must generate 12% pre-tax return on equity investment to achieve a goal in eight years. Now, suppose the actual return in year three is 10%, two percentage points short of the expected return.

If you do not bridge this shortfall, the gap can widen by the end of eight years. You can bridge this gap with more contribution into equity investments. But how will you raise savings without cutting into your current consumption? You can transfer some amount from satellite portfolio to core portfolio in any year the core faces a shortfall.

Conclusion

Transferring from satellite to a core portfolio will reduce trading capital. You can transfer the amount from the core back to the satellite once you create buffer capital in the core portfolio. Suppose you have ₹1 crore equity investments and the expected annual return is 12%.

After you transfer from the satellite to the core portfolio, suppose the equity investment earns 14%. You can transfer two percentage points of the investment value, ₹2 lakh or the actual amount, which is lower, back to the satellite portfolio.

(The author offers training programmes for individuals to manage their personal investments)

Personal Loans

Rates and Charges		Loan amount 5 lakh Tenure 5 years	Loan amount 1 lakh Tenure 5 years	(% of loan amount)
Name of Lender	Interest Rate (%)	EMI (Rs)	EMI (Rs)	Processing fee
HDFC Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to Rs 6,500
Tata Capital	10.99 onwards	10,869 onwards	2,174 onwards	Flat Rs. 49
State Bank of India	10.00-15.00	10,624-11,895	2,125-2,379	Up to 1.50% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
ICICI Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 2%
Bank of Baroda*	10.15-18.00	10,660-12,697	2,132-2,539	Up to 2% (Max. Rs 10,000)
Axis Bank	8.90 onwards	10,355 onwards	2,071 onwards	Up to 2%
Kotak Mahindra Bank	10.99 onwards	10,869 onwards	2,174 onwards	Up to 5%
Bank of India	10.85-16.15	10,834-12,199	2,167-2,440	Up to 1% (Min. Rs 250; Max. Rs 15,000)
Canara Bank	9.70-15.15	10,550-11,934	2,110-2,387	0.25% (Rs. 500 - Rs. 2,500)
Punjab National Bank	10.25-16.80	10,685-12,373	2,137-2,475	Up to 1%
HSBC Bank	9.75 onwards	10,562 onwards	2,112 onwards	Up to 2%
Federal Bank	11.75 - 18.99	11,059 - 12,968	2,212 - 2,594	Up to 3%
Union Bank of India	8.90 - 12.65	10,355-11,287	2,071-2,257	Up to 1% (Max. Rs 7,500)
Bajaj Finserv	10.00-30.00	10,624-16,177	2,125-3,235	Up to 3.93%
Punjab & Sind Bank	9.60-13.85	10,525-11,595	2,105-2,319	0.50%-1%
Indian Overseas Bank	10.25 onwards	10,685 onwards	2,137 onwards	Up to 0.75%
UCO Bank	9.95 - 13.20	10,611-11,428	2,122-2,286	Up to 1% (Min. Rs 750)
IDFC FIRST Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 3.5%
Bank of Maharashtra	9.75-15.00	10,562-11,895	2,112-2,379	Up to 1% (Max. Rs 10,000)
Central Bank of India	11.25 onwards	10,934 onwards	2,187 onwards	Up to 1%
IndusInd Bank	10.49 onwards	10,744 onwards	2,149 onwards	Up to 3.5% (2% for instant personal loans for limited period)

*Interest concession of 0.10% to customers opting for group credit life insurance.

Car Loans

Rates and Charges		Loan amount 5 lakh Tenure 1 year	(% of loan amount)
Name of Lender	Interest Rate (%)	EMI (Rs)	Processing fee
Union Bank of India	7.50-10.00	10,019 - 10,684	Up to Rs 1,000
Punjab National Bank	7.60-10.70	10,043 - 10,797	Up to 0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 1,500)
Bank of Baroda	7.60 - 11.35	10,043 - 10,959	Up to Rs. 2,000
Canara Bank	7.45-11.45	10,007 - 10,984	0.25% (Rs 1,000 - Rs. 5,000)*
Bank of India	7.60-12.55	10,043 - 11,262	Up to 0.25% (Rs. 2,500 - Rs. 10,000)
UCO Bank	7.35-10.00	9,983 - 10,624	0.5% (Max. Rs 5,000)
State Bank of India	8.70 - 9.85	10,307 - 10,587	Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 4,000
Bank of Maharashtra**	7.45-11.75	10,007 - 11,059	0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
Indian Overseas Bank	7.55-12.00	10,031 - 11,122	NIL
ICICI Bank	8.40 onwards	10,234 onwards	Up to Rs. 8,500
HDFC Bank	8.15 onwards	10,174 onwards	Up to 0.5% (Rs. 3,500 - Rs. 8,000)
Karnataka Bank	8.14-11.64	10,172 - 11,031	Up to 0.60% (Rs. 2,500 - Rs. 11,000)
Federal Bank	7.65-9.00	10,055 onwards	1% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 50,000)
Punjab and Sind Bank***	7.50-14.00	10,019 - 11,634	0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
Indian Bank	7.50-9.65	10,019 - 10,513	Rs. 1,200
Central Bank of India	7.60-9.30	10,043 - 10,452	0.50%(Rs. 2,000 - Rs. 20,000)

*50% waiver on processing fee till September 30

**0.25% interest rate concession for existing home loan borrowers and other existing customers having at least 6 months of relationship with the bank.

***Concession of up to 50% on processing fee for PSB Apna Vahan Sugam.

Rates and charges as on July 29

Source: Paisabazaar.com

LOCAL HERO

Commonwealth Games poster boy
Kerr delivers mile gold at home



REUTERS

Fresh from setting a World record in the mile, Josh Kerr delivered a Commonwealth Games gold in front of home fans at Glasgow on Saturday. Kerr, who was 12 seconds slower than the mark of 3m 42.66s he set in London last month, finished ahead of Australia's Cameron Myers (3:55.26) and Kenya's Timothy Cheruiyot (3:55.41).

MIXED FORTUNES

Indian relay team finishes sixth,
Jamaican quartet clinches gold



AFF

The Indian mixed 4x400m relay team of Vishal T.K., Rajesh Ramesh, Rashdeep Kaur and Neeru Pathak finished sixth (3:20.32) at the Commonwealth Games in Glasgow on Saturday. The gold medal was won by Jamaica (3:10.97). England bagged silver with 3:11.58 while Nigeria completed the podium (3:12.85).

INSATIABLE

Double medallist Gulveer
eyes more podium finishes



GETTY IMAGES

Gulveer Singh said it felt great to win two medals at the Commonwealth Games, but insisted that he will continue to strive for more podium finishes. "I am happy with the bronze medal (in 5000m). But I want to win more medals. I am still hungry. With the Government's support, Indians can do well in athletics".

SETBACK?

Spearhead Bumrah likely to
miss Test series against Lanka



FILE PHOTO

Jasprit Bumrah is likely to miss India's two-Test series in Sri Lanka, says a report in *Cricinfo*. The BCCI medical team has advised the premier pacer to allow more time for his recovery from a left-knee issue. No replacement has been announced so far. Bumrah has not bowled since the second ODI against England in Cardiff on July 16.

A highly satisfying show by the
Indian contingent in Glasgow

The boxers make a significant contribution to the country's medal tally; Gulveer, with a double podium finish, turns out to be the brightest star among the athletes; Asmita and Harsh bag historic gold in judo; Mirabai proves her class yet again

CWEALTH GAMES

K. Keerthivasan
GLASGOW

The people of Glasgow were warm and welcoming, displaying immense hospitality towards visitors who landed for the Commonwealth Games here.

On the roads leading to the stadiums and inside the venues, the volunteers were a shining example of kindness, respect and helpfulness. They went out of their way to make everyone feel at home. True to its official slogan, 'People Make Glasgow', the city once again showed it's the people who make the Games special.

For many Indian athletes, the cold weather did pose a challenge and affected their performances to some extent. But they refused to use the conditions as an excuse, instead using it as an opportunity to learn and compete with dignity and pride.

India's tally of 13 gold, 17 silver and nine bronze was one of its best returns in the quadrennial event. It reflected the steady growth of Indian sportspersons on the Commonwealth stage and their ability to adapt to different conditions. Though it would not be fair to compare the previous editions as Glasgow was a scaled-down Games featuring only 10 sports.

Boxing's contribution to India's overall medal tally



Striking it rich: Lovlina finished with a silver while fellow boxers Jaismine, Priya, Preeti, Sakshi and Arundhati took home the gold. PTI

was significant and impossible to overlook. It was easily the the country's best-ever showing in the sport in the Games history, with a haul of 10 medals, including seven gold and three silver.

The boxing arena at the Scottish Event Campus here was transformed into a sea of Indian supporters. The competition witnessed fierce contests, with England, Canada and Northern Ireland fielding some of their top boxers.

However, weightlifting was somewhat of a disappointment for India. Head coach Vijay Sharma had expected a medal haul of "around 10", but the team could not touch double digits and finished with eight medals – one gold, six silver and a bronze.

Bindyarani Devi, who had won a silver at the 2022 Commonwealth



Sachin and Ankush continued India's domination in boxing. AP



Games in women's 55kg, was expected to improve on that, but she ended up with a bronze in 58kg.

Much was expected from Raja Muthupandi in the men's 65kg category. However, he fell short, finishing second despite a spirited effort.

Mirabai Chanu continued to win hearts with her exploits. The humble Indian weightlifting star claimed her third suc-

cessive Games gold medal, adding another glorious chapter to a remarkable career and cementing her status as a Commonwealth legend.

Gulveer Singh was the standout performer for India in athletics. The 28-year-old achieved a rare feat by winning two medals in a single Games.

His historic silver in the men's 10000m and bronze in the 5000m, achieved in

a strong field featuring several Kenyans and world-class competitors, highlighted his ability to take on elite opposition and deliver.

The Indian athletics contingent also improved on its 2022 Birmingham Games tally, winning 10 medals – five silver and as many bronze – even though a gold remained elusive.

The historic gold medals in judo by Asmita Dey and Harsh Singh enhanced India's impressive overall campaign.

Para sports also made a huge contribution to India's kitty as the gutsy athletes scripted history with a record seven medals.

Like every edition, Glasgow brought its share of triumphs and setbacks, moments of joy and lessons to be learnt for the Indian sportspersons.



Raising the bar: Gulveer became the first Indian to win two medals in athletics in a single edition of the Commonwealth Games. AFP

Gulveer breaks new
ground for Indian
distance running

K. Keerthivasan
GLASGOW

Gulveer Singh etched his name in the annals of Indian athletics at the Glasgow Commonwealth Games. The 28-year-old broke new ground for Indian distance running on the Commonwealth stage by winning two medals in a single Games.

Gulveer had made history by clinching a silver in the men's 10000m, India's first-ever medal in the event at the Games.

Gutsy display

He returned to the track on Saturday and produced another gritty performance in a competitive field to secure the bronze medal (3:24.95s) in 5000m. Mathew Kipsang of Kenya won the gold in a time of 13:23.61 while Ky Robinson of Australia bagged the silver (13:24.70).

Cornelius Kemboi of Kenya came within striking distance of overtaking Gulveer, but the latter shifted

Gulveer secured the bronze medal in 5000m with a timing of 3:24.95s. The 28-year-old finished behind Kenya's Kipsang and Australia's Robinson

Keeping pace

Gulveer stayed with the pack for almost the entire race, even when he wasn't setting the pace. At the 1000m mark, he kept pace with the leaders, alongside the likes of Kipchumba, Robinson, Mohammed Ahmed, Dan Kibet and Kemboi. He remained firmly in contention, consistently featuring among the top five.

The blip came around the 2400m mark when he slipped to seventh, but Gulveer quickly regained his position in the front group, ensuring he was well placed to finish well on the home stretch.

Tilak is South skipper
for Duleep Trophy

Sports Bureau
HYDERABAD

Tilak Varma will lead South Zone in the Duleep Trophy, starting later this month in Bengaluru. Andhra batter Ricky Bhuji will serve as Tilak's deputy.

The 15-man squad includes India international Karun Nair, who last played for the national team in the Anderson-Tendulkar Trophy in 2025.

A reward

Promising players like Karnataka's R. Smaran, the leading scorer in the previous Ranji Trophy season (950 runs), and Hyderabad's K. Himateja are also part of the contingent.

M.N. Vikram Varma has been appointed as the head coach.

By virtue of reaching the final in the previous edition, where it lost to Central, South has received a direct entry into the semifinals.



Tilak. FILE PHOTO: K. MURALI KUMAR

The squad: Tilak Varma (Capt.), Ricky Bhuji (Vice-capt.), N. Jagadeesan (wk), Abhinav Tejrana, Shaik Rasheed, K. Himateja, R. Smaran, Karun Nair, Tanay Thyagarajann, Shreyas Gopal, K. Sai Teja, T. Vijay, Vidwath Kaverappa, Aman Khan, and M.D. Nidheesh.

Ankur, Yashaswini secure titles with contrasting wins

CWEALTH TT

Amol Karhadkar
NEW DELHI

Ankur Bhattacharjee and Yashaswini Ghorpade emerged as the men's and women's singles champions as India capped a dominant campaign by winning four of the five gold medals at the 22nd Commonwealth Table Tennis Championships at the Thyagaraj Sports Complex here on Sunday.

The men's final, featuring two of the brightest prospects in Indian table tennis, lived up to the expectations. In a pulsating 70-minute contest, Ankur staged a stirring comeback to overcome Payas Jain, making a strong statement after narrowly missing out on a place in India's Asian Games squad.

Yashaswini, meanwhile, added a major title to her growing resume by defeating the fancied Sreeja Akula. Both the finalists had been pushed to the limit in



Trophy collectors: Ankur rallied from a game down while Yashaswini dominated the summit clash. The Syndrela-Sreeja pair and Taneesha-Manav duo won the women's and mixed doubles crowns. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

the semifinals earlier in the day. Yashaswini had edged teenager Syndrela Das 11-9 in the deciding game, while Sreeja had survived an equally stern examination from Olympian Sutirtha Mukherjee to win by the same margin.

The draining last-four

match, however, left little trace on Yashaswini. She quickly settled into the final, repeatedly finding the mark with her forehand topspins to deny Sreeja any rhythm. The victory served as redemption after she and Divyanshi Bhowmick had gone down to



Sreeja and Syndrela in the women's doubles summit clash earlier on Sunday.

While the women's title battle was largely one-sided, the men's final ebbed and flowed. Payas' powerful forehand topspins initially outweighed Ankur's trademark backhand win-

ners as the Delhi paddler moved within a game of the crown at 3-2. But Ankur showed remarkable improvement in service returns, reeling off nine consecutive points in the sixth game to force a decider.

The seventh game brought another twist. A

yellow card for protesting Payas' service appeared to disrupt Ankur's concentration as he slipped 4-7 behind. But the Kolkata youngster used his timeout to regroup, returned with renewed purpose and completed a memorable comeback to earn the biggest title of his career.

The results:
Men: Singles: Final: Ankur Bhattacharjee bt Payas Jain 11-8, 9-11, 7-11, 11-8, 4-11, 11-4, 11-9;
Semifinals: Payas bt Manush Shah 11-9, 11-7, 5-11, 12-10, 11-9; Ankur bt Manav Thakkar 8-11, 11-8, 11-8, 11-8, 11-8.
Doubles: Final: Shen Qi Wong & Javen Choong (Mas) bt Manav & Manush 11-9, 12-10, 11-7.
Women: Singles: Final: Yashaswini Ghorpade bt Sreeja Akula 11-6, 11-1, 8-11, 11-7, 13-11;
Semifinals: Sreeja bt Syndrela Das 10-12, 11-7, 11-8, 12-10, 9-11, 9-11, 11-9; Yashaswini bt Sutirtha Mukherjee 6-11, 11-5, 7-11, 11-9, 5-11, 11-4, 11-9.
Doubles: Final: Sreeja & Syndrela bt Yashaswini & Divyanshi Bhowmick 11-8, 11-13, 11-8, 11-6.
Mixed doubles: Final: Taneesha Kotecha & Manav bt Ai Xin Tee & Richard Rui Zhe Yap (Mas) 11-8, 10-12, 10-12, 11-9, 11-5.

Near-perfect Tanvi stands tall to clinch maiden World Tour title

The 17-year-old beats Nguyen to become the youngest Taipei Open champion; she is the first Indian woman to win the crown since Saina in 2008



Holding her own: Tanvi stayed in control barring a few hiccups. BADMINTONPHOTO

BADMINTON

Press Trust of India
TAIPEI CITY

Teen Indian sensation Tanvi Sharma clinched her maiden BWF World Tour title, defeating sixth seed Nguyen Thuy Linh of Vietnam in the women's singles final of the Taipei Open Super 300 badminton here on Sunday.

The 17-year-old, hailing from Punjab, needed just 36 minutes to beat World No. 21 Nguyen 21-16, 21-16.

"I did not expect to win a title here, so I am really happy," said Tanvi, who became the youngest champion in Taipei Open history at just 17 years and 222 days.

Coached by P.V. Sindhu's former mentor Park Tae-sang, the youngster is the first Indian to bag the Taipei Open women's



I was quite nervous, but I tried to give my 100%. I was going step by step, match by match

crown since Saina Nehwal in 2008.

"I was quite nervous, but I tried to give my 100%. I was just trying to deliver my best. I was going step by step, match by match. I played really well in every match," added Tanvi, who dropped only one game all week.

"I have to do a lot more to play Super 500 and 750s. So, I will be keep working hard."

In the title decider, the Indian made a flying start, catching the Vietnam player at the front court with deft drops played with the same action used for a smash.

After surging to a 10-2

lead, Tanvi made a string of errors to allow Nguyen to reduce the deficit to six points at 9-15. She, however, regained control in the closing stages of the opener and sealed it with a cross-court smash.

In the second game, the Vietnamese opened up a 3-0 lead before Tanvi racked up a series of points to hold a three-point edge at the interval. The Indian gradually stretched the advantage, her deception once again fetching crucial points.

At 19-12, Tanvi unsuccessfully challenged a line call after being ruled late, but she soon earned seven match points with a smash. She squandered three of them in a nervous finish before settling the issue.

In a heart-warming gesture, Tanvi took off her gold medal and placed it around Park's neck before the two posed for photographs.

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TNCA LOWER DIVISION



Abdul's breezy ton wins it for NUC
CHENNAI: K. Abdul Riyaz's 50-ball 103 helped NUC beat Bank of India by 65 runs in the TNCA VI-A league match played recently.

In another clash, T.S. Audlin scalped six for 19 and bowled St. Mary's CC to a 91-run win over Amar CC.

The scores: V-D: Venkateswara CC 315/6 in 50 overs (S. Dhinakaran 80, V. Naveen Kumar 114 n.o., E. Mukesh 31, V. Arun Kumar 41, V. Logeshwaran 3/87) bt ICI 155 in 39 overs (S. Prithviraj 44, V. Logeshwaran 32, K. Gowtham 3/21).

VI-A: NUC 262/9 in 30 overs (B. Sanjeevan 61, K. Abdul Riyaz 103, S. Vasantha Kumar 4/61) bt Bank of India 197/5 in 30 overs (S. Mohana Kumar 48, V.C Prasanth 69 n.o., M. Deepan Ghosh 37 n.o., V. Saravana Guru 3/27).

Pegasus 180/6 in 30 overs (R.G. Sudharsanan 32, D.K. Vigneshwar 80 n.o., M. Tharun 3/36) bt Halifax 142 in 27.3 overs (Sharavanan 42, N. Kothandaraman 3/16).

St. Mary's 193/7 in 30 overs (Madan 38, C.K. Deepak Kumar 58, Karthikeyan 32, Rajkumar 3/20) bt Amar CC 102/9 in 30 overs (T.S. Audlin 6/19).

Anna University 207 in 29.3 overs (S. Ramkumar 59, J. Praveen Kumar 49, J. Daniel Raj 3/24, S. Sudharsan 3/63) bt Cosmopolitan Club 197/9 in 30 overs (Arvind 31, S. Vignesh 30, S. Pravin Kumar 3/43).

VI-B: Ashok Leyland 183 in 29.5 overs (V. Mohan 52, R.P. Dilli Dinesh 4/23, V. Anirudh 3/42) lost to Jai Hind CC 186/8 in 30 overs (Ajay Duenman 35, T. Samuel Durairaj 39, K. Rohith 40, K. Sridhar 3/31).

AISC 152/9 in 30 overs (A. Anirudh 3/25) bt Eccentrics CC 142 in 29.3 overs (G. Sakthi Mahendran 45, S.M. Diwakar 4/39, Vijay Thomas 3/26).

MFL 171/6 in 30 overs (Johnson Peter Xavier 42, M. Sriraman 47) bt Chennai Corporation 151 in 27 overs (M. Karthik 45, S. Kishore Kumar 30, M.S. Siva Kumar 4/32, Manikanta Syama Sundar 3/27).

Kohinoor XI 186/8 in 30 overs (A.K. Suresh 50 n.o.) bt IAF (Tambaram) 167/9 in 30 overs (Y. Abishek Yadav 47, R. Sukumar 3/21).



Triumphant: Round-4 winners Rudra Gokulnath, Kairav Roberson, Rehan Khan Rasheed and Aaruthran Prabhu. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Aaruthran claims Mini Under-10 class title

Sports Bureau
CHENNAI

Aaruthran Prabhu produced a brilliant performance in the Mini Under-10 class as the fourth round of the IAME India Series Karting promoted by RA Motorsports and organised by the Madras Motor Sports Club at the Madras International Karting Arena concluded on Sunday. Equally impressive was Chennai's Rehan Khan Rasheed (Momentum Motorsports) who dominated the Junior class, winning the Super Heat and the Finals.

The results (provisional, subject to post-race scrutiny):
IAME X30 - 125cc Seniors (Finals, 16 laps): 1. Kairav Roberson (MSPORT) (13mins, 25.527secs); 2. Armaan Dhawan (Leap Frog Racing) (13:28.204); 3. Krishna Premchandrar (Peregrine Racing) (13:39.470).
Super Heat (14 laps): 1. Kairav (11:49.326); 2. Armaan

(11:51.159); 3. Madhusudhan (Kartkrew Motorsports) (11:57.715).
Juniors (Finals, 14 laps): 1. Rehan Khan Rasheed (Momentum Motorsports) (11:59.263); 2. Adithya Pratap (Momentum Motorsports) (12:00.274); 3. Abhishikt Barse (Crest Motorsports) (12:00.341).
Super Heat (12 laps): 1. Rehan (10:13.559); 2. Abhishikt (10:18.583); 3. Adithya (10:19.663).
IAME X30 - 60cc Mini Class (Finals, 12 laps): 1. Rudra Gokulnath (NKRA with Momentum) (11:09.173); 2. Eeshan Swaroop (Kartkrew Motorsports) (11:12.044); 3. Ridhaan Anil Kumarr (Red Rabbit Racers) (11:15.912).
Super Heat (9 laps): 1. Shiv Neel (NKRA with KKM) (08:26.592); 2. Rudra (08:26.645); 3. Eeshan (08:33.161).
Mini Under-10 (Finals, 12 laps): 1. Aaruthran Prabhu (Kartkrew Motorsports) (11:09.300); 2. Yeshwin Vinay Kishore (Peregrine Racing) (11:14.188); 3. Parth Singh (NKRA with KKM) (11:50.956).
Super Heat (9 laps): 1. Aaruthran (08:25.834); 2. Aarav Sureka (Rayo Racing) (08:27.395); 3. Yeshwin (08:33.378).

Samaleswari pulls off a shock win over Mohammedan

Sports Bureau
KOLKATA

Debutant Samaleswari Sporting pulled off a major surprise by defeating two-time champion Mohammedan Sporting Club 3-2 in a thrilling Group B match of the 135th Durand Cup at the Salt Lake Stadium on Sunday. The Sambalpurbased side took a two-goal lead before half-time through strikes from Basit Ahmed Bhat and Russian forward Marat Tareck. Mohammedan responded strongly after the break, with Lalthankima and Lalngaisaka scoring.

Veer Arjun Joshi produced a fine free-kick in the 81st minute to restore Samaleswari's lead.

Mohammedan SC's substitute Adison Singh went red-carded in injury time.

The win saw Samaleswari complete its group campaign with six points from three matches to finish atop the table. Mohammedan remained second with three points from two matches.

The result: Group B: Mohammedan SC 2 (Lalthankima 60, Lalngaisaka 66) lost to Samaleswari Sporting 3 (Basit Bhat 11, Marat Tareck 27, Veer Arjun Joshi 81).

Infantino struggling to survive: former IOC marketing chief

Agence France-Presse
PARIS

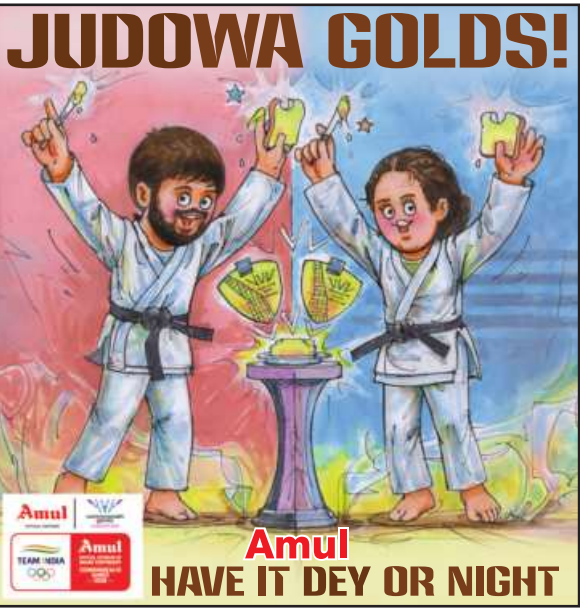
FIFA president Gianni Infantino's leadership has become "radioactive" and his 10-year reign as head of world football "is over", a former head of IOC marketing said.

A FIFA plan to raise up to \$4.2 billion, based on a valuation of \$20 billion, through private investment leaked to the media on Tuesday.

Following a global reaction, Infantino shelved the scheme on Saturday.

"I do not think we have ever seen such a fast fall from grace by a sports leader," Michael Payne, former head of marketing at the IOC, added.

"One week ago, Infantino was riding high from delivering a very successful World Cup, and expected to run unopposed for



election next year to continue his mandate as president of FIFA. Now Infantino will struggle to survive the month. How does he find himself in this mess - gross hubris!"

The signs are not good for the 56-year-old Swiss, with European football's governing body UEFA and CONCACAF among those expressing their discontent over his leadership.

AROUND THE CITY

Jishnu delivers sensational spell for Tiruvallur
TENKASI: S. Jishnu's seven for five was the highlight of Tiruvallur's 240-run win over Mayiladuthurai in a Group-G match of the TNCA inter-district under-14 tournament on Sunday.



Jishnu (Tiruvallur, 7/5).

The scores: Group-G: At Tenkasi: Tiruvallur 294/6 in 50 overs (D. Pramodhan 90, Kaashish Rai 82) bt Mayiladuthurai 54 in 31.3 overs (S. Jishnu 7/5). Chengalpattu 191/6 in 50 overs (Nithin Vidyush 59) lost to Erode 192/4 in 35.3 overs (V. Anish 69, A.G. Dhanvanthan 56 n.o.).

Inter-school cricket tournament
Friends Cricket Academy will conduct an inter-school tournament for under-12 boys at N.M. Green's ground from August 7. Contact Abdul (9962404093).

10 TN athletes selected for World u-20 meet
Ten athletes from Tamil Nadu will represent India in the World Athletics under-20 championships to be held in Eugene, Oregon, the USA, from August 5 to 9.

TN members in India squad: Uwin Anand (800m), Jithin Arjunan (long jump), Neil Samraj (4x100m relay), Ranjith Kumar (4x400m relay), Nakul Prabhu (4x400m relay), Dharanidharan (javelin), Ambrish (high jump), Roysan (triple jump), Bhavana (4x100m relay) and Thiya (4x400m mixed relay).

Tharun overcomes Karthikeyan's challenge
S. Tharun (RTTHPC) rallied from two games down to defeat S. Karthikeyan (Chennai) 9-11, 8-11, 11-4, 11-3, 11-9, 11-3 in the men's semifinal while Shriya (SK Academy) outclassed S. Nalene Amrutha (MVM) 11-6, 11-9, 11-5, 11-3 to storm into the women's summit clash of the fourth TNTTA-SK State-ranking table tennis tournament, conducted by SK Academy at the SDAT High Performance Centre.

Other results (semifinals):
Men: M.R. Balamurugan (Chennai) 11-7, 11-2, 11-2, 11-9. **Women:** S. Amruthapushpak (RBI) bt Kowshika (ICF) 6-11, 12-14, 11-9, 11-8, 4-11, 11-1, 12-10.
U-19: Boys: M. Mohammed (SK Academy) bt K. Akshay Bhushan (Chennai) 11-8, 11-8, 11-4; Nikkhil Menon (Chennai) bt K. Umesh (RTTHPC) 11-5, 11-4, 11-9. **Girls:** B.R. Nandhini (MVM) bt I. iniya (ITTC) 11-6, 10-12, 11-3, 12-14, 11-9; N. Sharvani (Mylapore Club) bt B. Varnica (SSA-ERD) 11-3, 11-7, 11-8.

Tanveer does the trick for Team Petronas TVS Racing

Sports Bureau
COIMBATORE

Team Petronas TVS Racing's star rider Abdul Wahid Tanveer emerged the overall winner of the MRF 2W Rally of Coimbatore, the opening round of the MRF MOGRIP - FMSCI Indian National Rally Championship for two-wheelers, here on Sunday.

"Coimbatore has been my favourite track for a very long time. It was pretty close in the first, but thereafter I pushed myself midway through to take the day's honour," said Tanveer.

Team Petronas TVS Racing's Aishwarya Pissay finished on top in the women's class and Deepan Kumar in the Star of Tamil



Plenty to cheer about: The overall winners of the MRF 2W Rally of Coimbatore. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Nadu category. Joseph Mahalson, the Coimbatore District Manager, MRF Limited, gave away the prizes.

The results (Top three categories only): **Class 1 (Super Bike Pro Expert):** 1. Abdul Wahid Tanveer (Team Petronas TVS Racing) 00:47:27; 2

Shlok Vikram Ghorpade (Team Hero Motorsports) 00:48:00; 3. Samuel Jacob (Team Petronas TVS Racing).
Class 2 (Super Bike Expert): 1. R. Nataraj 00:48:54; 2. V.S. Naresht 00:51:15; 3. Amogh Nag 00:51:46.
Class 3 (Super Sport up to 165cc): **Group B:** 1. L. Nithyan 00:53:25; 2. L. Bharath 00:54:01; 3. Varun Kumar 00:55:37.

LIVE TELECAST

Durand Cup: Sony Sports Ten 2, 5 & LIV, 4 & 7 p.m.
West Indies vs Pakistan: Second Test, Day 2, FanCode, 7.30 p.m.

The eternal crisis-man with a penchant for the big stage

When the mood seized him, which wasn't too often but not rare as hen's teeth either, Rahane cut a dashing picture at the crease, powerful off the backfoot and felicitous off the front. Lord's and the MCG seemed to bring the best out of him maybe because he is a strong student of history and knows the prestige attached with performing optimally there



THE GIST

▼
Australia in 2020-21 was Rahane's brightest hour, a shining beacon of not just his batting chops but also his tactical awareness, his man-management skills, the uncanny ability to think on his feet and his innate calmness that was more the need of the hour than Kohli's unquestionable fire

▼
A 4-0 whitewash was the predicted outcome at that stage but somehow, Rahane masterminded an extraordinary fightback. By the final Test in Brisbane, how India still managed to keep the scoreline at 1-1 remains a great mystery.

▼
Rahane's fabulous 112 was the catalyst for an instant backlash in Melbourne and once the skipper had shown the way, how could Pujara, Pant, Vihari and Ashwin not follow suit?

R. Kaushik

Michael Atherton is regarded as the greatest English opening batter of his generation, almost a natural successor to that other wonderfully accomplished technician who also hailed from the north of the country and who will rank among the top openers of all time, Sir Geoffrey Boycott.

Earmarked for the English captaincy from very early in his career - remember the famous FEC (Future England Captain)? - the Lancastrian was a grand mixture of technical expertise and remarkable concentration. He was a pleasing stroke-maker, without a doubt, but stroke-making won't be the first thought when one hears the name Michael Atherton.

At a time when English batting was desperate for solidity at the top of the order, Atherton loomed as the panacea, his unflappability instilling a sense of calmness and confidence within the batting groups. In a career spanning 115 Tests, the currently 53-year-old articulate and understated commentator and analyst produced numerous fantastic essays, as is to be expected. It is his highest Test score, however, that is still spoken of with awe and reverence, not just by those privileged to watch it first-hand or those who saluted his commitment on television, but even by those of succeeding generations who might not have seen him negotiate even a single ball during his long stint at the crease.

The epic unfolded at the Bullring that the New Wanderers in Johannesburg goes by. And make no mistake, it truly is an amphitheatre. Even without a single bum on the seats beyond the boundary buntings, Wanderers can be an intimidating stage. Standing in the middle, with neither bat nor ball in attendance, you can feel the stands closing in, the heat rising to your face, hands suddenly clammy and the heart beating at the rate of knots. One can only imagine what it must be like to take guard, gladiator-like, with Allan Donald and Meyrick Pringle and Brian McMillan and a very young Shaun Pollock chomping at the bit, desperate to have a go.

The first Test of the five-match series in 1995-96, in Centurion, had ended in a tame draw with not a ball bowled on the last three days. Pollock, on debut, had provided glimpses of his extraordinary talent with three for 98 from 29 overs while Atherton, the captain, ground out a five-and-a-half-hour 78 in England's 381 for nine declared.

South Africa called the shots in Johannesburg, Pollock's three for 44 earning them a 132-run lead which they increased to 478 at which point Hansie Cronje decided he had enough runs, and time, to force a 1-0 advantage. England had to bat out the better part of two days to secure a draw - a tilt at a record target was out of the equation - and the odds heavily favoured the hosts, but no one had told Atherton that.

He wasn't just obdurate defence. By his own admission, for the first time in his Test career, which was into its seventh year at the time, he felt he was in 'the zone', that elusive and intangible state that sportspersons strive for with limited success. He played the hook and the pull -



In another era, Rahane might have been a longer-term captain, but because of the overlap with first Dhoni and then Kohli, he ended up leading the Test side just six times, all in an interim capacity when Kohli was either injured, rested or was away on paternity leave. India won four and lost none of those six Tests, a terrific achievement as four of those outings were against the Aussies, and three in Australia

horror, horror - and one ball after being dropped on 99 by Gary Kirsten off 'White Lightning' Donald, it was the hook that took him to three-figures. Atherton wasn't done; the skipper was unconquered and unbowed at the end, unbeaten on 185 - in nearly 11 hours (643 minutes) - after negotiating 492 deliveries in the first of several grand tussles with Donald to shepherd his team to an honourable draw.

This would remain the defining innings of Atherton's career, one that catapulted him to English folklore. And yet - we say this with no disrespect - Atherton finished his career with no more than a middling average of 37.69. And 16 hundreds from 212 innings.

Perceptions vary

It's amazing how perceptions vary depending on so many different factors, not least recency bias which might cloud a forensic audit of Ajinkya Rahane's international career in general, and his Test record specifically. Like Atherton, Rahane - who led India six times in Tests, almost entirely by default - also finished with an average of less than 40 (38.46, superior by more than half a run per innings to Atherton) but where the Englishman is hailed and eulogised, the stylish Mumbaikar leaves behind a feeling of what-if. What if he had converted even a quarter of his (26) half-centuries into hundreds? What if he had sometimes been a little more selfish? What if he had been a little less flamboyant? What if he didn't have to perform in the towering presence of Cheteshwar Pujara and Virat Kohli? What if...?

But like the great stylist from Hyderabad who took the steel in the Indian batting and fused it with style, Rahane will always be more than his borderline-modest numbers. No, one isn't falling into the trap of comparing Rahane with V.V.S. Laxman. Not by a long way. For starters, Laxman had far superior numbers - an average of 45.97 - and played numerous more match-altering knocks than Rahane. But like Rahane, Laxman had to operate in the giant shadows of Rahul Dravid and the peerless Sachin Tendulkar and, from midway through his career, the effervescent genius of Virender Sehwag. That Very Special managed to carve a niche for himself and more than hold his own in this illustrious company is credit to his magic, of course, but also to a single-mindedness that he doesn't get enough credit for.

In Laxman's example was a tack for Rahane to emulate, and a contemporariness that should have been

his greatest motivation. But let's leave that for another day. In his own way, Rahane contributed to India taking not a lot of time in tiding over a tricky transition phase which saw Dravid and Laxman play their last Tests in Adelaide in January 2012 (though no one knew it at the time), Sehwag slowly fall out of favour and Tendulkar walk away into the sunset in November 2013.

Dashing picture

When the mood seized him, which wasn't too often but not rare as hen's teeth either, Rahane cut a dashing picture at the crease, powerful off the backfoot and felicitous off the front. Lord's and the MCG seemed to bring the best out of him, whether because he is a strong student of history and knows the prestige attached with performing optimally there or simply because he liked the pace with which the ball came on to his bat. Strangely for an Indian batter hailed as a very good player of the turning ball, Rahane enjoyed greater success overseas - only four of his 12 tons came in India - which perhaps obliquely explains his average.

In another era, Rahane might have been a longer-term captain, but because of the overlap with first Mahendra Singh Dhoni and then Kohli, he ended up leading the Test side just six times, all in an interim capacity when Kohli was either injured, rested or was away on paternity leave. India won four and lost none of those six Tests, a terrific achievement what with four of those outings against the Aussies, and three in Australia. His captaincy debut, in Dharamshala in March 2017, was sensational; with the series tied 1-1, Rahane heeded head coach Anil Kumble's advice and unleashed left-arm wrist-spinner Kuldeep Yadav, who rode on tips from Shane Warne to pull the rug from under the feet of the great man's colleagues. Rahane himself counter-punched as India pursued a tricky target of 106 on a still-spicy deck against a fired-up duo of Pat Cummins and Josh Hazlewood, taking his team home from 46 for two with a racy unbeaten 27-ball 38.

But his greatest hour as leader came in Australia, on the Covid-adjacent tour in 2020-21 when Kohli left for the birth of his first child after the first Test. India looked out for the count after an eight-wicket drubbing in the Adelaide day-nighter, courtesy their lowest Test tally of 36 all out in the second innings. Alongside Kohli, pace ace Mohammed Shami was also ruled out of the series, with a broken forearm.

A 4-0 whitewash was the predicted

outcome at that stage but somehow, Rahane masterminded an extraordinary fightback. By the final Test in Brisbane - how India still managed to keep the scoreline at 1-1 remains a great mystery - Rahane had to make do without the services of Ravindra Jadeja, R. Ashwin, Hanuma Vihari and the irreplaceable Jasprit Bumrah. But India weren't going away, were they? Rahane's fabulous 112 was the catalyst for an instant backlash in Melbourne and once the skipper had shown the way, how could Pujara and Rishabh Pant and Vihari and Ashwin - who defied a hamstring strain and a back injury respectively to bat out more than three hours and secure a magnificent draw in Sydney in the third Test - not follow suit?

Need of the hour

Australia in 2020-21 was Rahane's brightest hour, a shining beacon of not just his batting chops but also his tactical awareness, his man-management skills, the uncanny ability to think on his feet and his innate calmness that was more the need of the hour than Kohli's unquestionable fire. To see his teammates respond to the urgings of their captain was heart-warming; India had a bowling 'attack' of little pedigree going into the Gabba decider, but Mohammed Siraj, Navdeep Saini, Shardul Thakur and debutants T. Natarajan and Washington Sundar - this group combined had played fewer than 10 Tests at the time - delivered at the most Australian of venues to set up a spectacular coup taken to its denouement by the steadfastness of Pujara and the enterprise and incandescence of Pant. The Gabbatoir was conquered for the first time in more than three decades, with the leadership group of Rahane and head coach Ravi Shastri at the heart of one of the most extraordinary fairytales in the five-day game.

It's a shame that Rahane led just once more in Tests, and by the time Kohli decided to call time on his career in South Africa in early 2022, his form had nosedived enough - just three 50-plus scores and no century in his preceding 28 Test innings - for Rohit Sharma to take over as all-format leader. After South Africa, Rahane played a mere three more Tests over the next 18 months before being put out to pasture - some three years before he officially called time on his stirring journey. Cruelly, perhaps, but there is little place for sentiment in competitive sport.

Rahane, though, will remain a sentimental favourite. The eternal crisis-man but not a fair-weather fill-the-boot types. Maybe that's something he should have been better at. Thanks for the entertainment, Jinks. And the Border-Gavaskar Trophy, of course.



India produces smart scientists but is struggling to retain them

Research flourishes when ideas compete but suffers when people compete for proximity to power; many of India's laboratories continue to operate within rigid hierarchies that would appear strange in leading scientific institutions elsewhere in the world

Biju Dharmapalan

Recent reports of nearly 120 scientists resigning from the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) have rightly raised concerns. The ISRO has been a symbol of India's scientific aspirations and such an exodus cannot be dismissed as an ordinary episode of employee turnover.

Resignations have occurred over the years but the scale of recent departures confronts us with the question: of why some of India's brighter scientific minds are electing to leave institutions millions dream of joining.

The phenomenon is not unique to ISRO. Similar stories have emerged from laboratories under the Council of Scientific and Industrial Research (CSIR), premier autonomous institutes, and several government-funded research organisations. Often these departures are hard to notice as part of a larger pattern because they occur one scientist at a time – yet together they point to a deeper issue deserving of national attention.

Real main reason

The most obvious explanation is salary but it is not sufficient. Scientists who have spent decades building their expertise and reputation rarely leave only because another organisation is offering a bigger paycheck. Many of those that are resigning are also in the latter half of their careers, and generally unwilling to risk financial and professional stability. No; what they want is something even greater: professional dignity, freedom of thought, and the freedom to work on their topics of choice.

Several researchers – many of whom are unwilling to go on record for fear of repercussions – in private characterise these institutions as places where bureaucratic power is increasing at the expense of that of science, and where it is becoming more risky to question authority. The tragedy is that while Indian science inherited world-class institutions, it also retained a colonial administrative mindset.

Research flourishes when ideas compete but suffers when people compete for proximity to power. Many of India's laboratories continue to operate within rigid hierarchies that would appear strange in leading scientific institutions elsewhere in the world. Young scientists often learn quickly that survival depends less on asking bold scientific questions than on understanding invisible administrative boundaries. In some institutions, even simple acts of professional equality are viewed as breaches of etiquette. Respect, instead of being earned through scholarship and mentorship, is demanded through designation.

A class system

In order to be creative, for example, a doctoral student should be able to



Representative image of the National Institute of Animal Biotechnology (NIAB) in Hyderabad. India is spending a historically unprecedented, but otherwise still insufficient, amount of money on scientific research. FILE PHOTO

challenge a senior scientist's hypothesis without fearing that his or her long-term career will be adversely affected. A young investigator should feel confident enough to question established ideas. The world's best research environments are the best because they allow just such interactions.

Attend an international scientific conference in Europe or the Americas and you will often witness something remarkably ordinary: Nobel laureates standing in the same cafeteria queue as graduate students, and young scholars openly questioning senior scientists during presentations. They are respectful – and the seniors know that – but that respect flows from intellectual contributions rather than via ceremonial protocols.

However, many Indian scientific gatherings continue to have a bureaucratic rather than academic culture. Distinguished speakers receive VIP badges, exclusive dining arrangements, and special hospitality while students and junior participants are treated as an entirely different class. Such symbolism is not harmless: it reinforces a hierarchy that has little place in science. Science has never progressed because someone occupied a larger office or enjoyed a separate lunch. Let us foster the many little interactions; they could make a big difference.

Speaking up

Equally worryingly, scientists rarely speak openly about unhealthy workplace cultures because the ecosystem is remarkably small. Today's reviewer may become tomorrow's selection committee member. Today's director may influence tomorrow's funding decision.

Several researchers – many of whom are unwilling to go on record for fear of repercussions – in private characterise some institutions as places where bureaucratic power is increasing at the expense of that of science

Occasionally, some disturbing information emerges, including allegations of harassment, vindictive administrative actions, and attempts to publicly discredit accomplished scientists. Whether every allegation withstands scrutiny is for due process to determine – but the recurring perception is immediately damaging.

As a result, many talented researchers are now moving to private research organisations, emerging deep-tech companies, universities abroad, and/or international collaborations where scientific autonomy has more room than administrative strictures. India's growing innovation ecosystem benefits from this movement to some extent but it is not a zero-sum: our national laboratories lose institutional memory and experienced mentors.

India is spending a historically unprecedented, but otherwise still insufficient, amount of money on scientific research. Excellent skills are now needed for new research missions, including those involving semiconductors, quantum technologies, artificial intelligence, biotechnology, and spaceflight. But whereas buildings can be built in a few months and, with adequate funds, sophisticated instruments can be bought, building an environment that

holds great scientists is a very long process, often taking decades.

Conscious effort

Today, India must increase administrative transparency in scientific institutions, and install robust systems to redress grievances concerning workplace harassment and mentoring-based leadership training to ensure a leadership free from command.

In parallel, we need a conscious effort to break free of the colonial bureaucracy that remains in the daily life of institutions. Respect should not disappear from scientific workplaces but it differs fundamentally from unquestioning deference.

India has repeatedly demonstrated that its scientists possess extraordinary capability. Our achievements in space exploration, vaccines, supercomputing, mathematics, biotechnology, and engineering stand as testimony to that talent. The challenge today is not producing brilliant scientists – our universities and institutions have figured that out. The challenge is to ensure those scientists can still flourish after they enter India's laboratories.

If we fail to reform workplace culture, the next generation may simply leave our public institutions. That will be an immeasurable loss. Science has always advanced through ideas that challenged power – not by power that silenced people or ideas.

(Dr. Biju Dharmapalan is Dean, Academic Affairs, Garden City University, Bengaluru, and an adjunct faculty member at the National Institute of Advanced Studies, Bengaluru. bijudharmapalan@gmail.com)

THE GIST

Recent reports of nearly 120 scientists resigning from the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) have rightly raised concerns

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India must increase administrative transparency in scientific institutions, and install robust systems to redress grievances concerning workplace harassment and mentoring-based leadership training

BIG SHOT



Greek firefighters try to extinguish a wildfire in the area of Porto Germeno, some 70 kilometres northwest of Athens in the region of Viotia, on Sunday. Greece faced multiple fronts and a growing damage toll after a week of wildfires that devastated over 12,000 hectares of forest and agricultural land, experts said. AFP

WHAT IS IT?

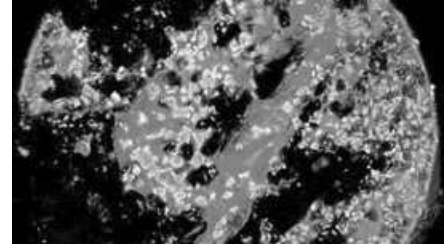
Extreme-event materials

Vasudevan Mukunth

Researchers have found a previously unknown metal alloy created by the blast of the Hiroshima atomic bomb in 1945. The material was found inside small, glass-like beads called hiroshimaites, which were recovered from the beach sands of Hiroshima Bay. These beads formed when the intense heat of the blast vaporised building materials, soil, and metals, which solidified as they fell back to the earth.

When the researchers examined the beads, they identified a micrometer-sized metallic grain embedded in the glass. It turned out to be a complex mix of iron, chromium, nickel, manganese, molybdenum, silicon, and aluminium – and it had a unique crystal structure.

The findings were published in *Science Advances* on July 29. The team has expressed belief that the alloy formed by ultrafast quenching: the explosion's fireball reached temperatures over 7,000 degrees Celsius, turning urban materials such as construction steel into a mixed metallic vapour. As the fireball expanded and rapidly cooled, the elements mixed in a way that is impossible under normal conditions. According to the researchers, their work shows that high-energy



Back-scattered electron image of the spheroidal hiroshimaites sample in which the alloy was found. BINDI ET AL., SCI. ADV. 12, EAEG8299 (2026)

plasma events like nuclear detonations can be natural laboratories where scientists can discover new materials that are difficult to synthesise in a scientific lab. The alloy already shares characteristics with other unusual high-entropy alloys and quasicrystals.

The researchers also wrote that their work shows how debris can preserve a “high-resolution record” of the chemical and physical environment during a nuclear event.

For feedback and suggestions for 'Science', please write to **science@thehindu.co.in** with the subject 'Daily page'

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Years after which disaster management personnel got hike

16 Delhi government has hiked the remuneration of disaster management personnel by up to 100%. Their previous salary hike was in 2009. The move will benefit staff working under the Delhi State Disaster Management Authority. PTI

Persons shifted to camps set up across Kerala following rains

5,792 Kerala CM V. D. Satheesan said that eight people have died, an equal number were missing and 13 injured in the previous day's rains which caused landslides, waterlogging and property damage in many parts. PTI

CBI cases related to exam irregularities awaiting trial

158 Around 158 cases linked to alleged recruitment exam irregularities are awaiting the start of trial in various courts despite the completion of CBI investigations, with some of them registered more than two decades ago, sources said. PTI

Amount earned as fines for ticketless travel in July

78 in ₹ lakh. The Jammu Division of Northern Railway generated about ₹78 lakh in revenue by penalising more than 10,000 ticketless and irregular travellers in July, reflecting intensified enforcement against fare evasion, an official spokesperson said. PTI

Number of persons killed in Spain's Ceuta migrant rush

72 At least 72 people died during the mass influx in recent days of migrants into Spain's Ceuta enclave, when tens of thousands of people mostly swam around the border post from Morocco, local officials said on Sunday. AFP

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Why are govt. schools shutting down?

Which States have witnessed the highest number of closures? How has school rationalisation affected children's access to education? Who bears the biggest burden of government school closures? Can the Centre step in to reverse the trend? Why has the Right to Education Act fallen short?

EXPLAINER

G. Ramakrishnan

The story so far:

A recent NITI Aayog report said some 94,000 government schools were closed over the past decade, an average of 25 a day, contributing to a 2.26 crore decline in government school enrolment. The government schools' share of total enrolment has fallen from 71% in 2005 to 49.24% in 2024-25.

Why are government schools shutting down?

School closures are happening across States on the grounds of rationalisation. The National Education Policy 2020 advocates such rationalisation but without endangering the concept of neighbourhood schools.

School closure numbers cannot be explained away as gradual demographic drift, urban migration and so on. Rather, it is a coordinated administrative decision taken in states where the poorest and most rural children have the least capacity to compensate for a school that has vanished.

Which States are among the worst affected?

Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh and Jammu and Kashmir lead in this.

In December 2025, Madhya Pradesh's School Education Department found that 7.37 lakh children in the state have no school records. They are not enrolled in any school – private or government.

In Jhabua and Shivpuri, for instance, 29,000 children fall into the “Drop Box” category – the department's term for those at imminent risk of dropping out. Across the State's 55 districts, more than 3,500 government schools recorded zero new admissions this academic session. Another 6,500 schools saw fewer than 10 admissions.

The department's response was to



School closures are happening across States on the grounds of rationalisation. THULASI KAKKAT

instruct every district education officer to paste lists of unmapped children on school noticeboards, contact them directly, and upload their details to the State portal.

Statewide, 11.38 lakh children fall under the “Drop Box” category. Another 1.23 lakh are already recorded as dropouts. A further 1.55 lakh have left school because their families were displaced or migrated for work.

The department's flagship outreach programmes, School Chalen Hum and the Home Contact Campaign, were built to prevent exactly this. The State's own audit of its own scheme found three-quarters of a million children whom neither programme had reached.

Government data tabled in the Lok Sabha in February confirms the scale. UDISE+ figures show the national count of government schools falling from 11.07 lakh in 2014-15 to 10.17 lakh in 2023-24, a decline of roughly 89,000 that lines up almost exactly with NITI Aayog's own count. Private schools nationally grew from 2.88 lakh to 3.31 lakh over the same decade.

Madhya Pradesh's government schools fell from 1.22 lakh in 2018-19 to 99,411 the very next year – a drop of roughly 22,600

in twelve months. Uttar Pradesh's government schools fell from 1.63 lakh to 1.38 lakh in that identical year, a drop of over 25,000.

Reports on J&K's rationalisation programme documented children now travelling 4 to 6 km daily to reach a functioning school, violating neighbourhood school mandates of Right to Education Act (RTE).

More than 4,300 schools were closed or merged under a rationalisation scheme, with the Lok Sabha's own UDISE+ figures showing the state's school count falling from 23,167 in 2020-21 to 18,785 by 2022-23, alongside nearly 13,000 vacant teaching posts reported separately in the state assembly.

What is the impact of the shutdown of government schools?

Government schools in India are not a neutral public utility used evenly across classes. They are, disproportionately, the schools of the poor – of Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes, and the poorer strata of backward-class communities. India is home to roughly 60% of the world's below-poverty-line population, and it is their children who fill government classrooms.

A 2019 National Sample Survey analysis found access to free education declining unevenly, with Muslim and Scheduled Caste and Scheduled Tribe households disproportionately marginalised from the schools nearest to them.

The burden falls disproportionately on girls who are the first to be withdrawn when the nearest school stops being nearby. What consolidation looks like on the ground is often a single teacher covering five classes at once – unable to know an individual child's background or tailor instruction, technically in breach of the Right to Education Act's staffing and quality norms.

Who is responsible for this trend?

In Lok Sabha, the concerned minister said education is on the concurrent list, and the responsibility for this trend lies entirely with States. But the RTE is a Central Act and the mandates on neighbourhood schools are the Centre's responsibility.

Further, the Centre seeks to intervene in State school education by making Central fund allocation for schools conditional on NEP implementation and also imposes a language policy. There are avenues for the Centre to step in against this trend.

The RTE Act, in force since 2010, guarantees free and compulsory education from age six to 14. RTE says nothing binding about the quality of what is delivered once a child is inside the classroom. It creates entitlements that children, by definition, cannot assert on their own – and parents, particularly poor and rural parents, often lack the legal and institutional capacity to enforce either. RTE assumes a symmetry of power between the state, the school, and the family that does not exist on the ground. RTE is not justiciable, in practice. School Management Committees, the one mechanism written into the RTE to give parents and communities a formal voice, largely go unconvoked.

(The author is Chairman, Central Control Commission, CPI(M))

THE GIST

Nearly 94,000 government schools have closed over the past decade under State-led rationalisation drives, with Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh and Jammu and Kashmir among the worst affected, leading to falling enrolment and rising dropout risks.

The closures have disproportionately affected poor, rural, Scheduled Caste, Scheduled Tribe and girl students, while questions remain over the Centre's role in enforcing neighbourhood school norms under the Right to Education Act.

Why does Kerala report a high leptospirosis burden?

Which groups are most vulnerable to contracting leptospirosis in the State?

C. Maya

The story so far:

Leptospirosis is a tropical zoonotic disease – a bacterial systemic infection caused by pathogenic Leptospira – highly integrated with an environment in which both humans and animals thrive. The disease, which began to be reported in Kerala since 1989, has been endemic in the State for the past three decades or more and has now become the communicable disease with the highest mortality profile. Leptospirosis is yet again in focus now, as the disease has claimed 50 lives just in the month of July this year.

What makes Kerala a hotspot for the disease?

Kerala's unique environment, with heavy monsoons, frequent floods and year-round moisture and humidity, creates ideal survival conditions for Leptospira bacteria in soil and water bodies such as lakes and canals. An

abundance of rodent and animal reservoir hosts live in proximity to human residential areas and farms. Paddy cultivation, pineapple plantations and canal cleaning activities expose large numbers of agricultural and manual labourers in productive ages to contaminated water, leading leptospirosis to enter the body through mucosal surfaces, abrasions or broken skin.

The Health Department maintains that according to the data of the National Centre for Disease Control, leptospirosis is endemic in at least 12 other States, with a high burden of disease. It is better disease surveillance, extensive diagnostic facilities and aggressive logging of both confirmed and probable cases that make Kerala seem like the State with the highest leptospirosis burden, it is claimed.

Which is the population most affected by leptospirosis?

Traditionally, leptospirosis has remained an occupational hazard, with people engaged in farming, dairy farming, and cleaning work – essentially, people are at

high risk of coming into contact with soil and contaminated water – contracting the disease. The disease typically affects those in the low socio-economic strata, but there have also been cases in urban areas, where women have contracted the disease following gardening (possibly bare-handed). Health Department has also identified that construction workers – especially the migrant workers who are employed in the road works on the State's Highways – are at heightened risk of contracting leptospirosis. The proliferation of wayside eateries has increased the chances of soil contamination by rodents.

What is making the case fatality rate go up?

Late diagnosis and rapid progression of the disease, leading to a cascade of lethal complications such as pulmonary haemorrhage and multi-organ failure between 4.5 and 5 days, leaving a narrow therapeutic window for clinicians to intervene, has been making leptospirosis a very unpredictable disease with a

difficult prognosis in recent times. Previously, patients showed signs of complications only by the second week of the illness. Clinicians note that in the post-COVID era, dysregulatory immune response triggering a rapid cytokine storm, with patients requiring mechanical ventilation, has been a feature of most infectious diseases.

Leptospirosis is associated with a broad spectrum of severity, ranging from subclinical or mild illness to severe disease, manifesting as fever, myalgia, conjunctival suffusion and gastrointestinal issues. It is only in 5-10% that the disease worsens and the prognosis becomes unpredictable.

In the initial days, the symptoms overlap with those of any tropical fever and hence people self-treat with analgesics and remain at home, till the symptoms suddenly worsen.

The laboratory diagnosis of leptospirosis also continues to be a challenge, because current serological tests for antibodies, such as ELISA, do not give confirmatory results in the acute phase of the disease.

Molecular diagnosis (PCR) has been introduced by the State for the early detection of leptospirosis; however, these tests are not widely available across districts. Intensive management and multidisciplinary support are crucial for a patient developing complications, but secondary care hospitals often lack round-the-clock emergency management facilities and human resources, all of which adds to the mortality.

What has been Kerala's strategy?

Chemo prophylaxis with Doxycycline – 200 mg twice a week – targeting the high-risk groups has been a strategy the State has always relied on to prevent leptospirosis. Clinicians point out that one cannot go wrong in starting doxycycline early on, even when the patients' symptoms might be hard to distinguish. The strategy is very effective even after one has contracted the infectious organism because, when taken as per the protocol, doxycycline prevents the replication of leptospira in the body. However, compliance has been poor and people seldom listen to the advisories issued by the Health Department.

The State's treatment protocol advised primary care physicians to maintain a high index of suspicion if a patient presents with fever and myalgia and without any respiratory symptoms and to start antibiotics as early as possible if the patient belongs to a high-risk category.

What are the modifications suggested in the strategy?

An experts' group has suggested that disease prevention strategies focussing on the vulnerable categories at high risk of occupational exposure to leptospirosis be devised and that risk communication be taken up as a campaign amongst these groups. Preventive gear, such as gum boots and heavy-duty gloves are to be provided to manual labourers and farm workers so that the risk of bare skin contact with contaminated soil and water is minimised.

